

A HOTPAST STORY

I KNOW WHO YOU DID LAST SUMMER

BOOK 4



BESTSELLING AUTHOR
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I Know Who You Did Last Summer, Book 4

A Hotpast Story

Paul Garland



Cerulean Erotica

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Chapter One

The car park was eerily quiet, save for the sharp, frantic sound of Jen's breathing beside me. I could feel her panic radiating off her, her hands trembling as she gripped the car door, her knuckles white, like she was trying to hold onto something—anything—to stop herself from losing it completely. But me? I was still in shock, looking at the USB drive in my hand like it was a grenade about to go off.

Jen's voice cut through the fog in my head. "What is going on, Ryan?" she asked, her voice barely more than a breathless whisper, desperate and pleading. Her eyes were wide, almost wild. "Why are you here? What's happening?"

I met her gaze, trying to find my own words, but I couldn't. The emailer's trick to lure me and Jen here together, the thumbnails I'd seen, the truth about Emmie that I'd learned, the chaos—felt too much to process. And then, my words came out all at once, in a clipped, almost mechanical tone. "What do you mean, Jen? What's happening? I should be asking you that question." I waved the drive in my hand in front of her face. "What the hell is on this?"

She looked down at it, her bottom lip trembling at what I was asking. She opened her mouth and closed it again before finally finding her voice.

"I've been blackmailed," she repeated. "Someone has videos... and photos. Of me. They've been demanding money. A lot of money." She looked away, out into the distance. "I... I had to sell part of the salon. I raised what I could, but... now I've lost everything. All of it. And the

blackmailer... they still played me. They fucking played me. They've pulled you into this when they said they wouldn't." She glanced at me, her eyes pleading for understanding. "And now I have nothing left."

I didn't know how to respond. I couldn't. This was all so totally unexpected and it took me a while to get my head around it.

"So that's what this is all about?" I muttered, still staring at the drive. "The texts between you and Emmie. The meetings. The sale of the salon. Does Emmie know? She must. And the two of you have kept all of this from me. Why? Did you think it was me?"

Jen's eyes widened in panic, and she shook her head. "No. Don't be crazy. It's not like that. I didn't choose this, Ryan. I didn't want this. But now, I—"

I cut her off, my voice sharp. "No. You're not the only one who's been dealing with secrets, Jen. Ever since the damn condoms fell out of Emmie's pocket, someone's been emailing me. Taunting me. Sending me clips of her—telling me they've got more." My jaw tightened, the bitterness rising in my chest. "I saw one of the videos. Of Emmie. They sent it a bit at a time. Emmie having sex with a man. And someone else was filming. Watching her. Recording it. It was..." I trailed off, not wanting to give away the shameful fact that I'd gotten turned on watching those videos, that despite everything, I was weirdly excited at finding out what was on the drive in my hand.

Jen blinked at me, processing, and for a split second, I thought I saw a flicker of understanding in her eyes. "What else?" she whispered. "Is that it? One video?"

"Today they sent me an image... thumbnails," I continued. "Of more videos—videos of Emmie with God knows who, and..." I swallowed hard, trying to keep my voice steady, "and there's at least one thumbnail with you in it."

Jen's face paled as the words settled in. She didn't respond immediately. For a few seconds, she just stared at me, her hands wringing the hem of her black hoodie top. Then, her eyes locked on the USB drive in my hand, and I knew her next question before she even asked it.

"So what are you going to do now?" she asked, her voice small. "Will you delete the videos?"

I stared down at the drive. The thought of doing that without watching them felt like it would crush me. I could feel her eyes burning into me, but I

didn't know what to say. A silence hung in the air between us.

"I've already seen one video," I said after a moment, my voice rough. "They're messing with my head, Jen. I'm the one who's been dragged into this when none of it is my doing. These videos—this blackmail—it's about me too. I deserve to know the truth."

"No," Jen shook her head, her voice firm now, sharper than before. "Ryan, you don't get to decide this. Not like that. The videos with Emmie—they're her past. They're not your property. They're from a time before we were even together. I... I know what it feels like, to be trapped by this. But you don't have the right to hold this over her—or me."

She stepped closer, her gaze never leaving the USB drive. "I'm the one they've been blackmailing. Not you. The videos of me on there... they're mine. I deserve to decide what happens to them. You certainly have no right to see them."

I opened my mouth to argue, but she cut me off, her voice now cold with the weight of everything we hadn't said. "Give the drive to me, Ryan. Please."

For a moment, I hesitated. I knew she was right. What choice did I have? She was right. Emmie's videos were Emmie's. Jen's videos—they were hers, not mine. If she wanted to try to put an end to this, then who was I to stop her?

But I couldn't simply let this go. She wanted the drive, but I needed something in return. I took a step closer to her, keeping my voice low, but firm. "Fine. You can have it. But I need you to promise me something, Jen. I want answers. I want to know everything. Everything that you and Emmie did while we weren't together."

Jen's gaze flicked down to the drive in my hand again, her eyes tightening, her jaw clenching.

"You don't get it," she finally said through gritted teeth. "It's not just about me. I'm protecting Emmie, too. If the truth comes out. If people know... what we did..." She trailed off, her eyes briefly meeting mine before she looked away. "It's not just me that's at risk. I don't know what might happen if anyone sees those videos—what's on that drive. I'm not just keeping secrets for me, Ryan. I'm keeping them for all of us."

I stared at her, the gravity of her words sinking in, and for a moment, I wasn't sure what to say. Jen was right but I still couldn't simply hand it over, not after everything I'd gone through to get to this point.

“What’s so bad that you can’t just go to the police about this?”

Jen’s eyes softened for a second, but she didn’t answer. Instead, she pulled out her phone and dialled quickly. “Pete,” she said into the phone. “We need to meet. The Red Lion. Now.” She hung up and turned to face me. “Let’s clean up this mess. Then we’ll go.”

I stood there, watching her. “Jen,” I said slowly, the frustration in my voice clear. “We need to keep this private. This isn’t something to involve everyone in, certainly not Pete... or anyone else. It’s already bad enough.”

Jen’s expression hardened, her jaw clenching. “Pete’s part of this, Ryan. You don’t understand. He’s part of the reason I’ve kept quiet for so long. I need his support. And I need time to think before I tell you anything.”

She turned and walked away, and I was left standing in the empty parking lot, the weight of the drive with the videos on it still heavy in my hand.

After she’d cleaned away the glass and made her car driveable, I followed her to the Red Lion, parking next to her car in the parking lot outside. When we entered the pub, a silent tension between us, Pete was already waiting, his friend Max sitting next to him in one of the corner booths. We walked over and I expected Jen to ask Max to leave, but she didn’t, sliding into the seat next to her boyfriend. As I was about to object to Max hearing any of this, Jen silenced me with a look, then didn’t waste any time in telling them, getting straight to the point.

“Ryan knows. We need to tell him what happened,” she said, her voice steadier now. The words hung in the air for a moment, the tension building like a bomb waiting to explode until Max finally looked at me with a pained expression.

He took a deep breath before speaking, his voice filled with regret. “Ryan,” he started, “I... I slept with Emmie. I’m sorry. I didn’t mean it to happen. It just did.”

My blood ran cold as his words hit me. “What?” I said, barely able to speak.

Max dropped his gaze, clearly ashamed. “It just happened. I never meant to hurt you, Ryan. I swear.”

I sat there, frozen, trying to absorb what he’d just said. “You fucked Emmie?”

Jen shifted uncomfortably, glancing at Max and Pete, then back at me. Her voice was softer now, but the tension in the room was suffocating.

“Ryan... You wanted me to tell you everything. You deserve to know the truth, you’re right. So let us explain.”

I felt my pulse quicken, my heart thumping in my chest. “You’re not going to keep anything else from me? Not one more thing?” I said, my voice low but sharp, every word cutting through the silence. “Tell me everything.”

Jen nodded, but her face twisted with guilt. “Okay, so to start... Max... is Shaun,” she said quietly.

I blinked, trying to make sense of it. “What? Max?” I almost stuttered, my brain scrambling to keep up. “What are you talking about?”

Jen exhaled slowly, glancing at Max fidgeting in his seat, clearly uncomfortable. “It happened a couple of months after you and Emmie split up,” she told me. “I was out with her, she was still pretty messed up after everything and needed cheering up, and we met Max and Pete. We got drunk... really drunk. And one thing led to another.”

She paused, her face paling, her breath quickening as she recounted what happened. “We ended up back at my house. Drunk. Over-excited. We’d been dancing all night and... You know how it goes. I slept with Pete that night, and Emmie... Emmie slept with Max in the guest room. I don’t think any of us expected it to happen. We hadn’t gone out deliberately to get laid but it happened. The next morning, it was awkward as hell, as these things are. Max and Emmie regretted it but there was nothing we could do about it. These things happen sometimes. Emmie was trying to get over you, maybe, I don’t know.”

I stared at her, my mind a mess. “So why didn’t you just tell me this before? Why keep lying? Why pretend Max was ‘Shaun’?”

Jen winced, the regret in her eyes deepening. “We didn’t want you to feel awkward, Ryan. You go to that pub with Luke, your favourite place. You see Max all the time and—” she glanced at Max, who seemed to shrink under her gaze, “—well, we didn’t want things to get uncomfortable for you. Emmie told you that you’d found the condoms and that you were curious as to what happened. So we came up with a story, told you it was Shaun. To protect you.”

Max, looking pale and deeply apologetic, shifted in his seat. “I wanted to tell you from the start, Ryan. I swear. Right after it happened, the very next time you came to the pub. I never wanted to hide it. But Emmie... she made me promise to keep quiet. She didn’t want things to get messy.”

I ran a hand over my face, the weight of it all crashing down on me. “So you’ve been lying to me for the past what... almost two years?” I glanced at Max.

Jen nodded. “We were trying to protect you. I swear, Trying to protect your marriage. It was never about us wanting to hurt you or anything like that.”

I looked down at my hands. I’d put the USB drive in my pocket and it burned there like some unholy relic. “Is this what the emailer has on you? Is this part of the reason why you’re being blackmailed? I don’t get it.”

Jen’s gaze faltered for a second, and she hesitated before responding. “No. There’s no video of that night. But...” Her voice grew quieter, almost reluctant. “There’s more. There was another time. A few weeks later, after Pete and I started dating properly.”

My heart sank. Somehow, I knew what she was about to say.

“Emmie and I went out again. I met up with Pete and Max met us later. We got drunk again and again, things got... out of hand.” Jen’s voice trailed off, and I could see the discomfort in her eyes. She wasn’t looking at me now, but staring at the floor.

“Tell me,” I urged, my voice barely a whisper.

Jen cleared her throat, clearly struggling with the weight of the words. “We went back to Pete’s and... things went further.”

“Further?” I could barely breathe. “Further how?”

Jen just stared at me, her hand reaching up unconsciously, fiddling with her long blonde hair until Pete cleared his throat, speaking up to help her out.

“We had sex,” he said, swallowing deeply before continuing. “The four of us, together, in my bedroom. Jen and me. Max and Emmie.”

My head was spinning. It felt like the room was closing in on me. “So, you’re telling me... what? That night, you and Pete... and Max and Emmie... you all—”

Pete looked into my eyes, read the questions I wanted to ask. “No. I didn’t fuck Emmie. Max didn’t do anything with Jen but... yes, we all saw each other naked, saw each other having sex... and yeah, it was weird and uncomfortable the next day. So much so that Jen broke up with me after that.”

Jen held up a hand, cutting him off. “But nothing happened after that. It was too messy. I broke up with Pete because it felt wrong. It was... weird. I

didn't know how I felt about it afterwards."

It wasn't quite a foursome but I still felt like I'd been punched in the gut. I couldn't speak. I just sat there dumbly, trying to absorb what they were telling me. "And now? What do we do now?"

"I need a drink," Jen swallowed, then turned to her boyfriend, her eyes soft. "Can you get me a drink? Give me some time alone with Ryan?" Pete and Max nodded, heading to the bar to order us drinks. I asked them to get me a beer too. I needed it.

"Pete and Max don't need to know about the blackmailer and the money and everything else," Jen said softly, once they'd left. "And you're right. This isn't just about me and Emmie. This is about you too. So, I'm sorry for bringing you here, making you find out this way but I thought it would be better coming from the horse's mouth."

I stared at Jen, trying to figure out how to respond. It felt like everything was coming at me too fast. I knew who 'Shaun' was now, had an inkling of what all of this was about and how it all started, but I had to know more. I needed to understand what was happening, there had to be more to it. Nothing Jen had told me explained how or why she was being blackmailed.

"Who else, Jen?" I asked, my voice tight. "Who else did Emmie sleep with? Who's in the videos? My neighbour... Laura saw Emmie bring at least three men home. I know the first two were Ethan and Mitch. Emmie's admitted as much but who else was there? I need to know."

Jen's eyes flickered away for a moment, and I could see the hesitation in her face. "You already know about Ethan and Mitch," she repeated softly, but there was something guarded in her tone, like she wasn't ready to say more.

I shook my head, frustration creeping in. "If you want this USB drive, you need to tell me, Jen. You promised."

She exhaled, clearly torn, then fixed her gaze on me. "Yes, Emmie was sleeping with Ethan for a while," she admitted, her voice strained. "But it didn't last. She was conflicted. It wasn't ever serious. As for Mitch... I don't think she slept with him. She never told me about it, and I'm fairly sure she didn't, but..." She hesitated, then added in a quieter voice, "Unless she kept it a secret from me too."

"Then the third guy?" I pressed. My pulse quickened. "A blond man?"

Jen's face tightened, her chest rising and falling rapidly as she wrestled with the situation. "I don't want to cause any more trouble than I already

have, Ryan,” she said softly. “You need to talk to Emmie. She’s the one who can tell you everything. It’s not my place to say more. It’s not right.”

Questions swirled in my head without answers. A pretty barmaid with curly black hair and bright blue eyes brought our drinks over and I took a long sip of the cold, refreshing beer.

“Emmie won’t tell me,” I said, my voice cracking, “If you won’t tell me, I’m just going to go home, watch these videos and work it out for myself.”

“No,” Jen reached out, grabbing my arm, squeezing painfully. “The reason we’re so protective of these videos—it’s all tied to Ethan. Emmie has to be the one to explain it to you. I can’t.”

“So I have to go to Emmie,” I said, more to myself than to Jen. Ethan. It was all to do with Ethan. “But she won’t tell me. I’ve asked several times about who she slept with but she won’t tell me. It’s in her past, she says. Nothing to do with me.”

“She’ll tell you now, Ryan,” Jen said, her voice soft but insistent. “I’ll speak to her, tell her what’s happened and then she’ll talk to you. She has to. We’ll figure this out together. Maybe we can find out who’s blackmailing us now we’re on the same team.”

I stood up, the tension in my muscles almost unbearable. I pulled my phone from my pocket, bringing up Emmie’s name, staring at it for a moment before hitting dial. It went to voicemail. I tried to call her a second time but with the same result. She wasn’t answering. I clenched my jaw, frustration boiling over. I took a deep breath, trying to process everything Jen had just told me. Where the fuck was Emmie? What was she doing?

“What about the night at your place? The four of you? You, Emmie, Max, and Pete—is that one of the videos?”

Jen shook her head quickly, her eyes darting away from mine. “No. No video of that night.” She sighed, running a hand through her long straight hair. “That night... it wasn’t recorded.”

I nodded, relief passing through me, but it didn’t last. Jen’s face turned serious, her eyes clouded. “But there is a video,” she said quietly, her voice tight with something I couldn’t quite place. “Of Ethan and Emmie. And... one of me with him.” She paused, making me think she was going to go into more detail but she didn’t. “That’s the one we can’t let get out. If that one gets out...” She trailed off, her voice breaking.

“You... you slept with Ethan?” The words felt like they were burning in my throat.

Jen nodded, her eyes welling up. “Yes. It’s... complicated, Ryan. Please. Just... give me the drive. Go home and talk to Emmie. I’m begging you.”

I hesitated, my fingers tightening around the flash drive in my pocket. I needed to know more—needed her to say it all, to explain it all. “I can’t just hand it over, Jen. Not yet. I need to know everything. All of it. Every detail. You promised.”

Jen’s eyes filled with tears now, her face crumpling finally. “Please, Ryan,” she whispered, the desperation in her voice turning into sobs. “I know it’s hard. I know you’re angry. You feel betrayed, lied to. But this is... I’m losing everything. I’ve already lost everything. If you see those videos... I’ll lose the one thing I have left. My dignity. Please, just... I need you to trust me.”

I was stuck, caught between my frustration, the overwhelming flood of questions, and the nagging voice in my head telling me I needed to leave. I needed to fix this, to get answers, but Jen was falling apart in front of me. The sight of her—vulnerable, broken—tugged at something deep inside me. I wanted to scream, to vent, but her pain was so raw, I could feel it in my bones.

“Ryan,” she whispered again, her voice breaking, “Please.”

I felt a sudden pull in my heart, something I couldn’t ignore. If I did this, if I took the drive home and watched the videos, I was no better than the blackmailer. I reached out, my hand trembling slightly as I placed the USB drive in her hand. Jen held it for a moment, not saying anything. Then, she looked up at me, her face wet with tears, mascara streaking down her cheeks, and I saw something in her eyes—something that told me I’d made the right decision.

I downed the rest of my beer and turned to leave but before I reached the door, I heard Pete’s voice. I looked back over my shoulder as he came over to Jen, wrapping his arm around her comfortingly. She leaned into him, sobbing quietly and I watched them for a moment before stepping outside into the cold, autumnal air.

Chapter Two

When I got home, my mind was still spinning. I'd come all this way—this long tortuous journey—for those videos, videos I'd had in the palm of my hand... and I'd left them behind. Perhaps it was for the best.

The lights were off and the house had a chill to it, so I put the heating on and called out Emmie's name in case she was upstairs, but there was no answer. She wasn't home. I walked into the kitchen, grabbed another beer from the fridge, barely registering the message alert on my phone when I heard the soft ping. Eventually, I picked it up, scrolling through the notifications: two missed calls and two messages but none from Emmie.

The first message was from Sophie.

I'm here for you if you need it, Ryan. I really like you, I hope you know how much now. I want to stay in touch. Please give me a call sometime.

I stared at the words, irritation gnawing at me. I didn't need her right now. Not with everything else going on.

The next message was from Laura.

I think I know who the third guy is. I'm home. Come over when you have a moment.

I ignored that message too, although it was difficult to resist the lure of knowing who she'd found. My head was too messed up, too full of everything Jen had just told me. If what Emmie's sister said was right, it didn't matter now who the third guy was. I'd find out, one way or another, but I didn't need to know right at this moment. Instead, I needed to find out the big secret that revolved around Ethan.

I checked the missed calls. The first was from Laura, she'd tried to call before messaging me. I dismissed the phone's prompt to ring her back or go around. The second was from Luke. I considered calling him back, telling him everything that had happened but I was too... drained. It would do me good to talk, get this off my chest, get his advice, but I just couldn't. Maybe I'd call him tomorrow, meet up for a drink. I didn't have work to go to until Helen straightened things up with Mitch. *If* she straightened things up with Mitch and it was a big if. I'd socked him in the jaw. It was hard to forgive that, especially if Laura had it wrong about him and Emmie.

I sat down heavily on the couch, everything bearing down on me when my phone buzzed suddenly, snapping me out of my head.

It was Emmie.

My heart skipped a beat, but my fingers paused for a second. I was still reeling from everything I'd learned, and I wasn't sure I was ready for whatever she had to say. I swiped to answer.

"Ryan?" Her voice was softer than I expected, but there was an edge to it, a weariness I didn't expect.

"Emmie," I said, trying to keep my tone even. "Where are you? I've been trying to reach you."

"I'm with Oliver," she replied quietly. "I needed somewhere to go." That made me sad but I couldn't let it show in my voice.

"You can come home. We need to talk."

"No. I need space." She hesitated for a long moment. "Listen, I've spoken to Jen. I know she's told you what's going on. The blackmail... The salon. That you know about Max... and the other time, when the four of us were together. And about Ethan."

My pulse spiked. "Emmie—"

"Laura's a fucking bitch for telling you any of this. I know she saw me but I thought I could trust her to keep it to herself. She said she would." I could hear the anger in her voice before she swallowed it down, forcing calm. "She's always had something against me, that one. Ever since Mark hit on me and I turned him down. To be fair to them, they talked me into getting back together with you but I could tell he was still pissed off that I rejected him, that I rejected their pervy little invite to whatever sex party they had planned. Hell, it wouldn't surprise me if Laura's tried it on with you, or she will in the coming days if she finds out what's happened."

It wouldn't surprise me if she's tried it on with you. That was too close for comfort and I took a deep breath to gather myself before I spoke. "Emmie, I —"

She cut me off again, her voice tightening. "And I'm not going to apologize for any of it. I didn't sleep with Mitch though," she added, her words more defensive now. "That's not what happened. It's complicated with Mitch. Besides, he was fucking that little tart that you work with. The weird one with the purple hair and the piercings. She gets her hair done at Jen's salon and even Jen says she's weird, always asking questions."

I swallowed hard, trying to push down the rising anger. Mitch was fucking Sophie? That didn't surprise me. Helen had told me that she'd fucked things up with Mitch. Was it something to do with that? It would make sense. And Jen knew Sophie? Did Sophie know that Jen was Emmie's sister?

"You didn't sleep with Mitch?" I questioned. "Really? Well, who else did you sleep with? Just tell me then we can move on."

There was a long pause on the other end of the line, and I could almost hear her biting back the words. "Ryan, I can't do this right now. I can't talk, can't come home. I need time. I'm staying at Oliver's for a few days. I need to figure all of this out. I... I don't know what to say anymore."

I felt like someone had knocked the wind out of me. "Emmie, please," I said, my voice cracking. "Just come home. We'll talk about everything. We'll figure this out together."

But her response was final, the kind of certainty in her voice that only comes when someone had made up their mind and won't change it. "I can't, Ryan. Not right now. Thank you for giving the USB drive to Jen. That was the right thing to do. She's going to delete the videos. But I promise we'll tell you everything, together, when we're both ready. I just need some space."

I felt a stab of frustration. "Space? So I'm just supposed to sit here and wait while all of this—" I paused, trying to steady my breath. "I don't know how much more of this I can take. I just want to know the truth, Emmie. Is that too much to ask?"

"I know," she said, her voice softening, though the underlying tension remained. "And no, it's not too much to ask but I'm embarrassed, Ryan. Ashamed. I didn't want this to happen. I didn't want you to keep asking questions, but you did, and this... this is the mess we're in now. Maybe if

you'd just taken my advice and let it go, none of this would have happened —”

“Let it go?” My voice rose despite myself. “Let it go? Emmie, I had to know. You were keeping things from me. All these secrets. I don’t know how you expected me to just pretend it was all fine.”

“I know you’re angry. I get it. But I just... I need to think. Get my head right.” She took a shaky breath, and when she spoke again, her voice was smaller, quieter. “I love you, Ryan. I really do. I always did, even when I was with Ethan and... I still do, that hasn’t changed.”

“I love you too,” I replied softly. “I wish I could go back and do things differently. But I can’t.”

“I know. I’m just... so confused right now.” Emmie sounded tired. She probably was. I sure was, physically, emotionally and mentally. “All of this... it’s made me question everything. But I know that I love you. That’s the one thing I know. I’ll figure the rest out. I just need some time, a few days. I promise that’s all it is.”

My heart shattered at the finality in her words, the distance between us feeling unbearable. “I don’t want to lose you, Emmie. I can’t. I’ll fix this. I’ll figure out who’s blackmailing us and get Jen’s money back. I won’t stop until I find out who’s behind all of this.”

“That’s so *you*, Ryan. And I love you for it,” she whispered, though there was an uncertainty in her voice. “But right now, I just... I need to be alone for a little while. Okay?”

I closed my eyes, the sting of her words cutting deep. “I understand,” I said, though my voice was barely a whisper. “I’ll call you tomorrow. But please... please don’t shut me out completely.”

“I won’t,” she promised, her voice wavering. “I love you, Ryan. I just need to figure myself out and work out how I’m going to talk to you about all this stuff.”

I nodded, even though she couldn’t see me. “Okay. I’ll be here when you’re ready.”

We hung up, and I sat there in the quiet, my phone heavy in my hand. I wanted to scream, to do something, but I knew there was nothing more I could do. I had to respect her wishes, even if it felt like I was losing her bit by bit.

The room felt colder now, emptier. I didn’t know what came next. All I knew was that Emmie had asked for space—and I didn’t know if I could

give her what she needed. I knew I had to try, but what about me? What was I supposed to do with all this anger, all these unanswered questions? I couldn't just sit here and wait. Not anymore.

In frustration, I grabbed my laptop. I didn't even know what I was hoping for anymore—the emailer had probably deleted their throwaway email address by now. But maybe they hadn't. Either way, sending them the email I was about to write would make me feel better, a sort of catharsis.

I pulled up the last email address the blackmailer had used, my fingers trembling as I typed.

You think you've won. You tricked me, made me believe we were going to meet. But instead, you forced me and Jen together. Why? You're a coward. Hiding behind a screen, pulling all the strings. You're pathetic.

I took a deep breath and, before I could stop myself, clicked send. But I didn't stop there. My fingers hovered over the keyboard as an idea struck me, something that felt as reckless as it was desperate.

Jen and Emmie won anyway. I let Jen have the USB drive. She's deleting the videos. I've spoken to Emmie, and we've talked. She has nothing to hide from me now. It's over. You might have got Jen's money, but in the end, you still lost. Emmie and I are closer than ever. If you were trying to hurt her, hurt me, split us up, you failed. Enjoy the money, coward.

I paused for a moment, my heart pounding before I hit the enter button. Could I really send this? Was I crossing some line, giving them exactly what they wanted—more fuel to drag this out? But how else was I going to find out who they were?

I hit send. The words would probably go into the void, to an email that no longer existed, never to be read by anyone. But in my heart, I hoped that they would read it, that it would provoke a response.

I sat back in my chair, waiting. My pulse was thudding in my ears, but nothing happened. No immediate reply. It felt like the moment had passed, and I was left staring at the screen, my last card played to no avail.

The laptop's cooling fan was the only sound in the room.

Then a new message notification popped up in my inbox.

I clicked it, my stomach flipping as the email loaded. It was from the blackmailer.

Well played. You let Jen have the drive? I didn't think you'd do that. But it's not over. Do Emmie and Jen think they can just walk away and delete everything like it never happened? Are they that naïve? Are you? Do you

honestly think Emmie and Jen will tell you the truth? All of it? You're fooling yourself.

My heart skipped a beat as I read it, the words sinking in. It felt like a direct hit, but there was something more—something worse coming. And then, as if to confirm my worst fears, a second email appeared.

There was no subject line. No words. Just a link.

I moved the mouse pointer over it, my entire body tense. For a moment, I just stared at the screen. What was this? With a deep breath, I clicked the link.

A Google Drive folder opened. The label read *The Videos*.

My fingers shook as I clicked on it.

There they were. Four videos, labelled Emmie 1, 2, 3 and 4.

The blood drained from my face. They hadn't deleted them. They'd kept copies. My mind raced with doubts and, to my shame, excitement. I couldn't do this, could I? I'd given Jen the USB drive, an indirect promise that I wouldn't watch these, that I trusted her and Emmie to tell me what happened.

I stared at the screen, my chest tight. The emailer had said there were photos too but he didn't send them. This was just the videos. My throat went dry at the thought of what I was about to see.

Suddenly, a knock at the door broke through the haze of my thoughts. I jumped, startled, my finger was just about to click the mouse button but I stopped. Was it Emmie? Had she changed her mind and come home? I hoped—no—I needed it to be her. The other thought, that it might be Laura, annoyed me. Her involvement in all of this would only somehow make it worse. Still, I couldn't sit here, staring at the screen.

I stood, my legs stiff as I walked toward the door. The knock came again, more insistent this time. I reached for the handle, my pulse hammering in my ears, but when I opened the door, I found not Emmie, not Laura—but Luke.

“Hey.” He smiled but then his face shifted, concern flooding his features as soon as he looked at me properly. “Hey, what the hell's going on, man?” he asked, his eyes scanning my face. “You look... fucked.”

I stood there for a moment, frozen. I opened my mouth, but nothing came out at first. I realised that the events of today had all suddenly caught up with me.

“Ryan?” Luke pressed, his tone softening. “Talk to me.”

I shook my head, not knowing where to start. Instead, I muttered, “Something’s happened,” and found myself stepping back to let him in.

Luke didn’t hesitate. He walked in, his brow furrowed, eyes looking round the room before landing on the couch where my laptop sat open. I could hear his footsteps behind me, but I didn’t look at him as I sat down and he joined me on the sofa, leaning in slightly.

“What happened?” he said, his voice low but insistent. “What’s going on, Ryan? You look like you’ve seen a ghost.”

I couldn’t bring myself to say the words. What could I say? I didn’t know how to explain it to him, how to tell him everything that had been piling up over the last few days. The fight with Mitch, the meet in the alleyway, Jen being blackmailed, the videos, the way I felt like I was losing control.

But I did have control. I had the videos. I stared at the laptop, at the four videos begging me to play them.

It didn’t matter if Luke saw, did it? He was my friend, he’d always been there. He probably knew more than he was letting on anyway. And at this point, what difference did it make?

Luke shifted closer, his concern growing as he watched me closely. “Ryan,” he urged, sitting on the edge of his seat, his hand resting on the arm of the couch. “This is the video of Emmie you were telling me about, right? And there are others too?”

I felt numb. I could only nod, the shock of everything taking hold. Luke’s eyes never left the screen, his face tense with anticipation as I moved the mouse pointer back to the first video. I could feel his presence beside me, his breath even in the quiet room.

“She fucked Ethan,” I said, my voice robotic. It felt like I was on autopilot. “She fucked some other guy too, a blond guy. My next-door neighbour saw her.”

“The hot redhead?”

“Yeah,” I said, a bitter taste on my tongue. I took a swig from the beer bottle next to the laptop on the coffee table. “That’s her. Laura. I fucked her, by the way. The other day. I fucked her while her husband watched.”

“Ryan?” Luke stared at me. “What the... you fucked her? How? What happened? Where is Emmie anyway?”

He looked over his shoulder as if only just noticing that she wasn’t there.

“She’s not here. Oh and she sucked Mitch’s cock too, I think. And she fucked Max,” I mumbled. “Max from the Red Lion. While we were apart.

Jen's fucking his friend, Pete."

Luke fell silent. My normally easy-speaking friend was lost for words. The silence in the room stretched between us and I could feel the weight of Luke's eyes on me as he watched me for a moment before turning his attention to the laptop.

Before I could stop myself, I clicked on the first file, *Emmie_1*. I stared at the screen, my chest tight as Emmie appeared, naked, sitting on the edge of a bed, the triangular play icon positioned over one of her large breasts.

This was it. There was no turning back now. I didn't care if Luke saw.

I clicked play.

Chapter Three

It was like all the air had been sucked out of my lungs.

Luke and I had just watched the first video. He'd been completely engrossed, his eyes never leaving the screen.

"Damn, man," he said under his breath. "Emmie is incredible. Hot as hell. You're so lucky, being married to her and getting that every night."

I'd not said a word yet, still finding it hard to talk. Then I clicked on the second video and it was as if everything stopped, the world around us, my heart, my breath.

This video was a continuation of the first. Where that video had ended, on the briefest view of a shoe and the floor, it started there, swinging up to look at the man who'd just fucked my wife.

Ethan. It was *Ethan*.

"What's wrong?" The grey-haired businessman looked at whoever was holding the camera, frowning. "Won't it turn off? Or is it the audio again?"

"Yeah, I don't think it recorded any audio," the person holding the camera replied.

My blood turned to ice in my veins. I recognised that voice. The camera turned a full 180 degrees, the image of Emmie naked, covered in cum, fleeting by until it settled on the camera holder's face

Jen.

What the fuck?

She studied the camera for a second, during which the frame froze for a few seconds. When it restarted, it was once again facing Ethan.

“It’s working now,” she continued. “Sorry about that. I’m sure it’s still a good video, sound or not.”

“That’s Jen,” Luke gasped, pointing out the obvious. “Jen and... Emmie. Is this for real, Ryan?”

“And the man is Ethan,” I told him, finally finding my voice. “Emmie’s old boss. Laura saw them together, so I knew about him but I didn’t know it was him in the video.”

We continued to watch, the glow of the laptop casting shadows around the room. Luke was sitting so close that I could feel the heat of his body as he angled himself toward the screen for a better viewing angle. I should have told him to leave, told him not to continue watching, but I didn’t. What difference did it make now? If Luke could watch his own girlfriend in porn movies, and he was okay with me seeing them too, then I couldn’t exactly deny him the same, could I? Still, a part of me felt uncomfortable, conflicted about sharing something so private to Jen, something so deeply personal to Emmie. But it was too late now.

“Did you know about Jen too?” Luke asked softly.

I couldn’t bring myself to respond. I watched, heart pounding, as the video continued. Ethan’s voice filtered through the speakers, talking about his love for making sex videos, how much he enjoyed making them, watching them, how much he admired porn stars, how many of them he’d fucked. The camera zoomed out, revealing the full scene. Emmie was wiping away Ethan’s cum with a tissue but then Jen passed the camera to her, and she held it as her boss continued talking.

“You know, Jennifer,” he used her full name, his deep voice echoing in the bedroom around them, “I’d love to fuck you. Are you sure you won’t reconsider taking your clothes off at least?”

“You’re lucky that I even agreed to film you.” Emmie’s sister shook her head, her long blonde hair falling into her face for a moment so that she had to push it back. She wore a pair of painted-on jeans and a close-fitting blouse that left a band of skin bare at her waist. “If it wasn’t for the fact you’re paying me, I wouldn’t be here at all.”

“I’ll pay you double,” Ethan grinned as the camera in Emmie’s hand panned back to him. “It’s not like you haven’t done this before, you two girls. Emmie told me all about the foursome you did with those two guys.”

Luke’s head swivelled towards me and I nodded. “Max and his friend, Pete.”

My friend's face would have been hilarious had the situation not been so intense. He leaned closer, eyes widening as the scene played out. "Man, not only has Emmie got it going on," he muttered. "She's incredible. And Jen too? Jesus, dude, she's just as sexy. But they get naughty together? This is un-fucking believable. You have to get a piece of this, man. Or have you already?"

I felt a rush of heat on my face, my jealousy intensifying, but I didn't object to what he was saying. I didn't know why I felt so conflicted but a part of me was ashamed of the excitement I was feeling. I didn't want to be turned on by this, but I was.

"No," I shook my head. "I didn't know about her and Jen until today."

Then the video faded out and for a second, I felt a swell of disappointment. Was that it? But it wasn't. The screen lit up again, the video continuing with Emmie cursing at the camera for turning off, then she resumed filming. She pointed the lens at Ethan, who was undressing Jen. The sound of their conversation was muted, but I could see the excitement in their movements. While the camera had been off, Ethan had somehow talked Jen into taking things further. Emmie's voice drifted into the audio, encouraging them.

"I told you Jen wasn't shy," she giggled. "You're going to have fun. Wait until you see her body."

Jen glanced over at the camera, raising one dark, sculpted brow and pressing her lips together. Ethan touched her face, and she turned back to him, her blue eyes locking onto the older man.

He reached down, slowly unbuttoning her blouse to reveal her pretty pink bra. Pulling it open, he savored her athletic body, her pert breasts, her unblemished skin as she shrugged the top off her shoulders. "Very nice," he said, running his hands over her, cupping her tits over the bra.

Jen didn't protest. She didn't pull away. Her gaze flickered toward the camera, meeting Emmie's eyes for just a moment before she looked down, almost resigned.

The world around me seemed to slow as my pulse quickened. Jen allowed Ethan to continue, unbuttoning those tight jeans and peeling them down her lean legs. Her pink thong matched her bra, sexy and small, almost a G-string.

Ethan couldn't resist any longer. He pulled her against his mature but still toned, fit, and completely naked body, and kissed her. Jen didn't resist. She

melted into him, her eyes shutting as he continued to caress her body. His hand found the clasp of her bra, twisting it open effortlessly. As she pulled the bra off, he went lower, sliding his fingers into her thong. I could see his knuckles working beneath the thin fabric. Jen broke the kiss, gasping at his touch. He whispered something that wasn't picked up by the microphone, and the two moved towards the bed.

They were going to fuck. Ethan eased Jen back onto the bed, and tugged at her thong, pulling it off to reveal her tidy landing strip. Her body — Emmie's sister — was exposed. I shouldn't be watching this, but I couldn't stop. She was so damn hot.

Emmie and the camera moved closer and zoomed in on them as Ethan climbed over her, once again kissing her, once again fingering her wet pussy. Their bodies tangled together urgently.

"Wow. Here we go." Emmie giggled sexily and then the camera was set down nearby with an audible thump, the view trained on the bed, on Ethan, on Jen, and as I watched, on my wife as she joined them—lying next to them to watch.

My balls clenched at the sight of Ethan pushing Jen's legs apart, delving his head between her thighs to lick her pussy. Jen gasped, arching her back, her nipples hard. She threaded her fingers through Ethan's salt-and-pepper hair then moaned softly, "Oh... fuck."

Emmie didn't merely watch. She shifted lower, sliding on her back to take Ethan's cock in her mouth. It was incredible, watching the two blonde sisters like this, sharing a man, one between his legs, the other with her legs splayed apart for him. This was what they had been hiding all this time. This was what they hadn't wanted me to see. Emmie and Jen, together with a man. If anyone found out about this—about their threesome—it could ruin their careers, ruin everything.

I wasn't sure how I should feel, but arousal overrode everything else. How could they hide something like this from me? How could Emmie, my wife, share herself like this with anyone, never mind Jen? I never knew she had this side to her. It didn't seem... real.

But it was real. I was watching it and I couldn't stop. There was no way the shameful desire inside me would let it stop now.

"You taste so good," Ethan's voice was muffled against Jen's pussy but then he pulled away, pushing Emmie back for a moment. His long, thick

cock was hard again, standing in front of him proudly. “I need to fuck you now.”

Emmie positioned herself next to them again, murmuring something into Jen’s ear as Ethan slid up between her thighs, placing the head of his impressively hard dick against Jen’s tight-looking slit. She kept her eyes trained on the older man, nodding tightly as he thrust forward, burying himself deep inside her in one smooth movement.

Jen cried out. “Uhhh fuck!”

“Fuck, you feel good,” Ethan grunted.

Her body was quivering as he began to fuck her. She rocked her head back, closed her eyes tight, and came on his cock. Already. It was incredible. Emmie held her hand, giggling at her sister’s horniness. Then Jen wrapped her long legs around Ethan’s back and the two of them fucked like animals, raw and passionately on the bed.

Like the videos I’d watched before, of Ethan with Emmie—before I knew it was Ethan—the man could *fuck*. Jen orgasmed again twice more as Luke and I watched, entranced. Emmie remained at her side, whispering into her ear and holding her hand as Ethan plowed her. Seeing the two sisters so close was almost as sexy as the actual sex. I felt guilty for thinking it but before I could come to terms with it, Ethan groaned loudly, pulling out and spraying a huge rope of cum onto Jen’s belly.

Emmie released Jen’s hand and sat up, kissing Ethan sexily, their tongues entwining as she reached down and stroked his wet, dripping cock. She whispered something to him before slipping from the bed, treating the camera to the full-frontal glory of her body as she approached it. Her nipples were hard, I noticed, as her large breasts filled the screen, blocking the view of the bed. Then, with a click, the second video finally ended.

“What did we just watch?” Luke managed to say, his voice hoarse. “That’s the hottest thing I think I’ve ever seen.”

I didn’t want to admit it but I agreed with him. I simply nodded and clicked on the next video. This one was different. When the video opened, I froze, thinking the black man standing naked in front of my equally unclothed wife was T.J. for a second, but I was wrong. It wasn’t him. This man was bigger, different. As the camera panned out, I saw his face and recognised him. He was the black pornstar that I’d watched with Charlene, Ethan’s current girlfriend.

“Emmie?” I whispered to myself, my eyes widening as I watched her take the porn actor’s super-sized cock into her mouth, beginning to suck him expertly. I couldn’t bring myself to look away, though the mixture of arousal and anger inside me began to surge.

Ethan spoke from behind the camera, coaxing Emmie into the act, encouraging her, directing her. “Just relax, Emmie,” he said, his tone soft but persistent. “It’s just sex. You wanted this, remember?”

My wife’s hazel eyes met the camera lens as she pleased the black guy, using her full range of blow job skills, teasing his cock to full hardness. It got long enough that she gagged on it as she tried to swallow the whole thing. She pulled back, gazing up at Ethan behind the camera.

“I don’t know,” she mumbled but the black man paid her no heed, picking her up and carrying her to the bed. “You wanted this, Ethan. Not me. I said I was curious but I’m not sure.”

“Hush,” Ethan calmed her. “Relax. You’re going to love it. Trust me. Your first big black cock.”

Luke and I watched, enraptured as the pornstar rolled onto his back. His dick was huge—like Coke-bottle thick—coated in Emmie’s spit, and completely shaved. He stroked it in front of her. “Climb on up,” he instructed Emmie.

My wife glanced one last time at the camera before straddling him. I had to remind myself that this happened while we were apart. Tried to tell myself that it didn’t matter as she took hold of his cock and rubbed it along her shaved slit, obviously uncertain whether she could take it. After another moment, she took a deep breath, placed it against her entrance, and slid down onto it.

“Oh, fuck,” she groaned. “It’s so... fucking... big.”

A knot of jealousy formed in my chest, watching Emmie with another man, her body writhing as she got used to his size—eyes closed, pink mouth parted, nostrils flaring.

“You’re so tight,” the man said. “Fuck, you feel good.”

“Oh... my God...” is all Emmie could manage between gasps and moans and it ignited something primal in me. It made me angry. Furious. But then there was this other part of me—the part I had been trying to deny—that felt a sharp pulse of desire. The way she looked, the sounds she made on a much bigger cock than mine and even Ethan’s—turned me on more than I was willing to admit.

I watched helplessly as the scene unfolded, the camera catching every intimate detail. Once she got accustomed to his size, she started to ride him hard, bouncing on his long, girthy dick through a swift orgasm.

He lifted her off of him like she weighed nothing, flipping her over onto all fours. Emmie assumed the position, wiggling her ass and glancing over her shoulder at him as he lined himself up. “You starting to like black cock?” he asked.

“Do it,” she hissed. “Put it back inside me. Now! Please, I need—”

He doesn’t wait for her to finish the sentence, ramming back into her hard. Emmie’s whole body shuddered, her head hanging low between her shoulders, her fingers gripping the bedsheets.

After that, Emmie was reduced to moans and grunts and orgasms as the black man railed her hard from behind. She may have been hesitant at first, but there was no doubt that she was into the sex now. It felt so violating, so raw. The worst part, though, was hearing Ethan’s laugh, his envious enjoyment at watching my wife cum with another man. Then, as he tried to turn the camera off, he complained that it wasn’t working again. “If it’s not my PC causing problems, it’s the damn camera,” he grumbled, fiddling with the buttons.

Emmie’s voice was softer now. The sex was ended, culminating in the pornstar shooting his load all over her face, a scene that I wanted to turn away from but couldn’t. “I’ve got a friend who knows a tech guy,” she said, almost apologetically. “I’ll get him to fix it.”

Then the camera finally turned off, and the third video ended.

Luke was silent now, his face unreadable as he sat beside me. We were both stunned, caught in the aftermath of everything we’d just witnessed. I could feel his eyes on me, but I couldn’t bring myself to meet his gaze.

“One last video,” I said, my voice rough as I double-clicked on it and pressed play. The final recording began, the tension in the room almost unbearable. The opening frame showed the thumbnail I remembered, the least interesting one of the four, a hand gripping the bedsheets tightly, and as it started, it was clear that the woman it belonged to was being fucked hard.

But then as the camera pulled back, I froze. We both did. It wasn’t Emmie on the bed this time. Nor was it Jen.

“Natasha?” Luke gasped, standing for a moment in surprise before quickly sitting back down to continue watching.

It *was* Natasha. Her dark hair flared out around her head, her slim form, perfectly hourglass-shaped with those perfect tits, tight waist and beautiful hips, beneath the cameraman on the bed. Her body writhed as a big cock drove in and out of her, the camera angle shifting downwards to catch everything.

“You’re still the best.” It was Ethan speaking as he fucked her. “To say you’ve had a lot of cocks, your pussy is still so fucking tight.”

“Nat’s been with Ethan too? Fuck,” Luke cursed. “Is there anyone he hasn’t fucking fucked? I mean, who the fuck is this guy?”

Only Luke could say the F word that many times in so short a space of time.

“Just fuck me.” His bride-to-be said the F word too, then moaned as Ethan pounded her shaved hole, driving in and out while recording it unsteadily with the camera until he grunted, keeping his cock inside her while he came. When he pulled out, he lowered the camera, capturing his seed oozing from her small but swollen pussy lips. Then the camera shifted, placed once again somewhere at the side of the bed but this time awkwardly facing upwards at the ceiling.

I was about to stop the video, but Luke stopped me, placing his hand over mine. I realised this wasn’t the end, there were a few minutes left on the progress bar below the video.

“I saw a video on your PC,” Natasha said, her voice cutting through the momentary silence. She sounded angry. “A video of you and that Emmie girl. I’m not happy about it, Ethan. I know I’m just your mistress. You’ve got a wife, and she’s cool with it, but it feels like you’re just screwing around with anyone you can find. I might be only your mistress, but don’t for a second think I’m okay with you fucking everyone.”

“But you’re special, Natasha,” Ethan replied. “You know what I’m like. I can’t resist a pretty girl. You’re my number one, I promise.”

“Well, if that’s true, you need to learn how to resist these pretty girls,” Natasha replied, her voice growing louder. “If you want to keep doing this, spending time with me, you need to treat me right. I need you to stop seeing this Emmie girl. I mean it, Ethan. It’s me or her. You need to choose.”

Ethan grumbled something in response, and the camera was knocked slightly, the view shifting to a different corner of the room. He finally managed to turn it off, but not before we heard Natasha’s last remark.

“You’re just like all the others. You’re just like everyone else.”

Luke looked at me, stunned, his face a mixture of disbelief and confusion. “So, Natasha knows about this? About Emmie? Why has she never said anything?”

I didn’t know what to say. I just sat there, numb, my mind blown. Everything we’d just seen, just heard... It all started to make sense.

I understood why Jen and Emmie were so protective of the videos. The two sisters had partaken in a threesome, one with payment involved by the sounds of it. They couldn’t let that get out. They’d be looked down upon, castigated, seen as dirty, weird sluts.

But why was there a video of Natasha bundled in with the other videos? Was this Natasha’s doing from the start? Was it her way of getting her own back on Emmie?

This changed everything.

And then an email appeared in my notifications. I frowned at the icon, clicking it with trepidation when I saw that it was from the same throwaway email as before.

You just watched the videos. I hope you enjoyed them. The words felt like a cold punch to the gut. Now you know what disgusting, relationship-wrecking cunts Emmie and her sister are. You could do so much better than her, Ryan.

Luke sucked in a sharp breath beside me. “What the fuck is this?”

“They blackmailed Jen, stole thousands from her, and now they’re trying to split me and Emmie up. I won’t let them.”

Luke’s face had gone pale, his expression hardening as he picked up my beer, taking a long pull from it. His hands were visibly shaking. I could see it now, the reality of the situation sinking in for him too. He’d gone from being excited, watching the videos of Emmie and Jen, seeing them naked and having sex, to this—learning that Natasha had kept a massive secret from him all along.

“Who is it?” Luke asked, his voice hoarse, his eyes wide as he placed the empty bottle down and scrubbed a hand through his hair. “Who’s doing this?”

“I don’t know,” I admitted, my voice strained with frustration. “But I’m going to find out.”

My eyes skimmed the message again, searching for clues, but before I could process anything, another attachment popped up. I clicked it, and my blood ran cold.

It was a photograph. Me and Luke, sitting side-by-side, watching the videos on the laptop. The picture was clear as day, the angle showing the dim light from the laptop illuminating our shocked faces and an image of Jen on the screen. It had been taken just now, but from where? I turned my head, working it out... through the front room window.

Without another word, Luke and I rushed outside, the door slamming open behind us, hearts pounding, adrenaline surging, our breaths misting in the air before us. We patrolled the area frantically, hoping to catch whoever had been watching us, but the front garden and the street were empty. There was no sign of anyone. No one was there.

This was bad—really bad. This wasn't just some joke. Whoever was behind this had been watching through the window, knew exactly what we were doing. But how? How was this even possible?

Chapter Four

I stood outside, staring up at the pure white moon that had broken through the dark clouds. Luke had gone, slamming his car door behind him and driving away after an argument that left the air between us heavy and raw. It had started with a simple question: *Where is Natasha, anyway?*

Luke's eyes had flashed, a defensive edge creeping into his voice. "Why? You're not accusing her of being behind this, are you?"

I couldn't help the bitterness that slid into my words. "I'm not ruling her out." I paused, forcing the words out slowly, as if saying them out loud might make me believe them more. "She's got motive, Luke. This all started around the time Emmie and I first met her. The video... you saw it. She was jealous of Emmie, Luke. She's angry."

I could see his face harden, his jaw clenching as if I'd slapped him. "You're really gonna accuse her of that? Why would she put one of her own videos in there? Why would she label it as an Emmie video? It makes no sense."

"Unless she wanted me to see it. Labelling it with Emmie's name is one way to get me to watch it," I shrugged. I should have stopped there, but the words spilled out like poison. "You want to defend her? Fine, but her knowing Emmie and not saying anything... That video, Luke. It changes everything."

Luke's eyes burned into me, his breathing shallow. "You don't get it, do you?" he said, his voice low but seething with emotion. "You think Natasha

is some sort of villain, but you've been blind to what's right in front of you. You've been blind to *her*, Ryan. To Emmie."

I felt the sting of his words before I even processed them. "What the hell does that mean?" I barked back, my voice rising, the anger clouding my mind.

"Maybe you should be asking Emmie these questions instead of blaming everyone else," Luke shot back. "She's the one that fucked around while you were apart. She caused all of this, not me, not Natasha." His words hit me like a slap, and before I could react, he turned and stormed away, climbing into the car and then speeding away down the road before I could stop him.

The anger that had been boiling beneath the surface had burst out and Luke had copped for it. What the hell was I doing? I didn't know who to trust anymore. I didn't know how much more of this I could take. My mind kept flashing back to the video, the images of Emmie and Jen, naked together, pleasuring Ethan. The shame, the guilt—it was all too much.

I didn't even realise how long I'd been standing there, lost in my thoughts until I finally snapped myself out of it. The silence in the house as I walked back in was crushing. I had to do something, find something to occupy my mind.

I moved to the sofa, sitting down and opening the screen of the laptop, the email from the blackmailer burning in my mind.

I saw you just watched the videos. Now you know what disgusting, relationship-wrecking cunts Emmie and her sister are. You could do so much better than her, Ryan.

The original email with the link to the videos was still there but I didn't click on it, tempting as it might be to watch the recordings alone now that Luke was gone. I checked my notifications again. There was nothing new, so I replied to the last email with its taunting, smug tone.

Tell me who you are. Let's meet. We can decide this between us, man to man, or man to woman, whoever you are.

But almost as soon as I hit send, another notification popped up—a bounce-back message. The email address had been deleted. Gone. Just like that.

Frustration boiled over. How was I supposed to get to the bottom of this if they kept covering their tracks?

I paced the room, running my hands through my hair, desperate for answers. My mind started working overtime, trying to make sense of the situation. Then, it hit me. One person who could have taken that photograph of Luke and I—who could have been that close to us—close enough to email the videos and then get to the window fast enough to take a picture of us, was Laura. She was right next door, and she had her strange habit of watching through windows. I had dismissed it before, thinking it was just her curiosity or playfulness, but now, in the light of everything that had happened, it seemed far more sinister.

I didn't hesitate. I grabbed my coat and headed out to see her. I needed answers, and I was going to get them, even if I had to drag them out of her. But when I rang the doorbell and she answered, I wasn't expecting the scene I walked into. She seemed surprised to see me, but before I could say anything, I saw the man standing next to her. A tall, athletic-looking Asian guy, broad-shouldered with dark, sharp eyes. He was shirtless and had the body of someone who played sports, rugby or something physical, the kind of man who made me feel small just standing there.

"Ryan," Laura greeted me, her tone light but there was something in her eyes—something like guilt, maybe? She was wearing a tiny black nightdress that clung to her svelte figure. Her flame-red hair was down, tumbling loosely over her shoulders. "This is Kenji," she introduced, her voice playful, tugging down the wispy nightdress. It barely covered her pussy. "I met him last night at Rapture. We've been... spending the day together."

Rapture was a nightclub in town. I froze. Kenji's presence here, in her house, made me feel even worse for some reason, but I buried the feeling of discomfort. I couldn't let this distract me. Seeing that Laura was in her underwear, her companion half-dressed, made it less likely that she was the one who'd taken the photo but I still had to be sure. These two could have staged this to cover up what they'd just done.

"What's going on, Laura?" I asked, my voice cold. "Why did I just get an email from someone, who took a photo of me and Luke watching the videos? Through my window, no less?" I paused, letting the accusation settle between us, then continued, "You've always had a thing for watching, haven't you?"

Laura stiffened, her eyes widening. Her nipples were hard, poking through the gossamer thin silk. "What are you talking about?" Her voice

wavered, but there was a defensive edge to it now. “What videos? What are you accusing me of?”

“I’m not accusing you of anything,” I snapped, frustrated beyond belief. “But whoever sent that email, whoever has been behind all of this—it’s someone close to me, someone who’s been watching me, someone who knows exactly what I’ve seen. You watched Emmie through the windows while we were apart. And now someone’s taken a photo of me through the window. Laura, I’m not stupid. Tell me it’s not you who’s been blackmailing Jen.”

Laura’s expression darkened, and she crossed her arms. “You really think that’s what’s happening here? I’m not a fucking blackmailer, Ryan. Whatever you’ve got yourself into, I’m not involved in any of it.”

Kenji stood a little straighter, his dark brown eyes narrowed with a mixture of confusion and irritation. “What’s going on here?” he asked, his voice calm but the tension in the air rising by the second. “I don’t know what kind of shit you two are dealing with, but I don’t appreciate being dragged into it.”

I ignored him, my eyes locked on Laura. “So this isn’t you? You’re not in this together?”

“Don’t be stupid, Ryan. Right before you arrived, we were fucking. We fucked all night last night. We’ve been fucking all day today. Yes, I’m a slut. There. I said it. Are you happy now?”

I shook my head, feeling a spark of jealousy but suppressed it as she continued.

“If I wanted to fuck with you and Emmie,” the redhead said coolly, her expression frosty, “I’d have simply gotten Mark to video you and me fucking the other day, and then showed it to Emmie. But I didn’t. Because all I wanted from you was some fun.”

“Oh, and you had your fun alright, Laura!” I yelled, my anger finally breaking free. My phone vibrated in my pocket and I pulled it out. It was Jen. I didn’t have time to deal with her right now, so I ignored the call, diverting my attention back to Laura and the Asian man standing before me. “Just like you’re having your fun right now. Does Mark know about this?”

Laura’s face paled, and for a second, I saw something shift in her eyes—hurt, confusion, maybe even regret.

But before I could say anything more, Kenji moved toward me, his chest puffing up in a challenge.

“Hey, back off!” he growled. “Don’t talk to her like that.”

I didn’t back down. “This is none of your business, man,” I shot back, my words sharp.

Kenji stepped closer, his eyes narrowing. “I’m making it my business,” he said. “You don’t come into a woman’s place and accuse her of things like that. Whatever’s going on, you can deal with it, but you’re not going to disrespect her in my presence.”

I felt the blood rush to my head. I was sick of this—sick of being pushed around, sick of everyone hiding things from me. I could feel my hands balling into fists, ready to fight, but before it could escalate, Laura stepped in, her voice trembling but firm.

“Enough!” she shouted, holding her hands up between us. “Kenji, stop. Ryan, please. Just... just go.”

“I’m not going until I know for sure that you’re not involved in this.” I stood my ground, refusing to move.

“Ryan, I don’t know who’s behind that email,” Laura said, her voice tinged with genuine frustration. “I swear to you, Ryan. I’ve told you what I know. What I saw.” She paused, looking away for a second before meeting my gaze again. “I tried to get in touch with you earlier. I’ve been going through Emmie’s Facebook friends list, as I promised I would. That guy I saw with her, the last one, the one with the blonde hair? His name’s Craig Dunn. He’s a personal trainer at the gym I think Emmie goes to. I’ve seen him at Rapture too. He goes every weekend, always picking up girls. He’s very fit... very sexy. I’d sleep with him if I had the chance, so I can’t blame Emmie for what happened.”

The words hit me like a punch to the stomach, and I couldn’t suppress the anger rising in my chest. Craig, Emmie’s personal trainer at the gym.

Laura looked down, her hands trembling slightly. “But I don’t know anything else, Ryan. I really don’t. I can’t tell you more than that. And yes, Mark knows about Kenji.” She tossed her hair back, her eyes meeting mine defiantly. “I texted him this morning and told him I’d spent the night with a new friend. Do you want me to show you?”

I opened my mouth to respond, but before I could say anything, Kenji moved closer, his presence suddenly feeling oppressive. He was looking between us, his jaw set in a hard line. “You need to leave,” he said flatly, the tone of his voice cold. “You got what you came for. The stuff you’re talking about is nothing to do with us. So just go, as the lady asked you to.”

She's no lady, I wanted to say but I kept my mouth shut. My blood boiled, but I knew when to back down. The last thing I needed right now was a fight. I shot Laura one last look, silently pleading for some kind of reassurance, but she just shook her head, not offering anything else. I turned and left without another word, the frustration and confusion gnawing at me as I walked out of the house and into the night.

I paced the short distance between our houses and as I got home, I heard the buzz of my phone in my pocket. I slipped it out and gazed down at the screen. Jen again. She had tried calling while I'd been at Laura's but I still wasn't ready to talk to her. I dismissed the call, my mind too clouded to deal with her right now. But then I noticed the voicemail notification. I hesitated for only a moment before tapping the play button.

Her voice came through, shaky and urgent. "Ryan, please call me. It's urgent. Please call me back."

I felt a tight knot form in my chest, but before I could call her back, another call came through. Emmie. I answered quickly, desperate to hear from her, hoping for something to make sense of all this.

"Ryan!" Emmie's voice was sharp, filled with a fury I'd never heard before. "Have you watched the videos?" She screamed at me through the phone, and for a moment, I froze, my heart pounding in my chest. "The emailer messaged Jen, Ryan. He sent a picture of you and Luke, sitting together. Is it true—you've watched the videos with him?" Her voice cracked, and I could hear the tears in it. "Tell me it's not true. Tell me that's not Jen I can see on the laptop screen."

My throat felt dry, my words stumbling out, but I couldn't seem to find the right ones to say. "Emmie, I... I didn't mean for it to happen," I started, but she cut me off.

"No, Ryan," she spat, then paused. "Do you know what? I don't want to hear it. You've seen the videos. You know what I've done. What Jen and I did. I never wanted you to know. I trusted you to stay out of my past. I trusted you not to watch the videos..."

"Emmie, listen. I understand you're angry but—"

"No. You listen, Ryan," she interrupted me, her voice laced with angry sobs. "I trusted you and you've thrown it all away. Just leave me alone. Don't call me again. Just leave me and Jen the fuck alone."

The line went dead before I could even respond. My phone slipped from my hand, crashing against the floor with a hollow thud. I was frozen, rooted

to the spot, my entire body trembling with anger and frustration. My heart was a mess of emotions, the crushing weight of her rejection juxtaposed to the anger I felt that she was judging me when it was her that had fucked half the town's population while we were apart.

A text came through and I opened it quickly. It was from Jen.

I can't believe you watched the videos. You tricked me. I asked you not to watch them, Ryan. How could you do that?

I replied straight away, my fingers a blur on the phone keyboard.

I didn't trick you. The blackmailer sent them to me. I couldn't help myself. I had to know what was so bad that you gave in to blackmail. Can't you understand that?

It took a few seconds, but she replied:

Whatever. Emmie's heartbroken. I don't think she'll ever forgive you. Why couldn't you just leave it all alone?

How had this gone so bad, so quickly? I sent another message as quickly as I could:

I'm sorry, Jen. Please, tell Emmie I love her. I'll find a way of fixing this, I promise.

Jen's reply was almost immediate:

We don't want you to fix it. We just want you to stay away from us. Leave us alone.

No, no, no. This wasn't happening. I sent one last text:

Jen, please. Are you with Emmie? Ask her to come home. I can explain.

But there was no reply after that. I tried calling her, tried calling Emmie but they didn't pick up. I couldn't breathe, couldn't think. I had no idea what to do next. All I knew was that Emmie—my wife—was done with me.

I'd lost her.

Chapter Five

I looked down, watching my piss stream into the bowl. My head throbbed like someone was drilling into my skull. The pale morning light streaming in through the window made it worse. I'd drunk way too much last night. Again.

The past few days had been a blur. Emmie wouldn't talk to me. She'd been alternating between staying with Ollie and Jen, as far as I could tell, and it felt like I couldn't even find a way to fix it. Jen was ignoring my calls, refusing to even reply to my messages. I'd called by the salon but it was closed. No matter what I did to try to get through to either sister, I felt like I was hitting a brick wall. Helen had told me to stay off work for a few more days, though it wasn't like I'd be to focus on anything right now. Not with my mind spinning like it was.

I stood there for a moment, shaking the last few drips from my cock when I'd done, the cold tiles of my bathroom beneath my bare feet grounding me as I tried to make sense of the past few days.

Luke was still furious with me. After an initial chat the day after we'd argued, he refused to talk about it, barely even looking at me the last time we'd crossed paths. He didn't want to hear my side, didn't want to understand why I'd accused Natasha. He'd spoken to her and she'd sworn she wasn't the emailer, and that only left me with more questions. Why hadn't she told us that she knew Emmie? Luke refused to tell me what she'd said to that, only that he'd talk to me more about it when the time was right.

My thoughts were a tangled mess, and the longer I waited for answers, the worse it all felt.

A knock at the door startled me, and then a shout followed quickly. “Ryan?” The voice was male but I wasn’t sure who it belonged to. “Ryan, are you home?”

It sounded like they were inside. I groaned, feeling my headache intensify. I must have left the door unlocked last night, drunk as I was. It was probably Luke. As ready as I was for Natasha’s side of things, the last thing I needed right now, with my headache and everything else, was to deal with him. But I knew I had no choice. I couldn’t let him upstairs, so even though I wasn’t in the mood, I dragged myself down the stairs and stumbled toward the door.

The house was like a disaster area. I hadn’t bothered to clean up in days, and every corner of it reflected my state of mind. Empty beer bottles littered the living room, some of them tipped over and staining the rug. I hadn’t cared enough to tidy up. I was just waiting for something to change, some kind of break that might allow me to breathe again, and until then I was occupying myself with—

“Been partying?” my visitor’s voice snapped me out of my thoughts. Mitchell fucking Davison had indeed already let himself in. I caught him mid-stride, his polished leather shoes tapping on the polished floorboards as he made his way into the front room.

“Are you out of your fucking mind?” I snapped, a surge of frustration leaking into my voice. What the fuck was he doing here? “Mitch? You think you can just walk in here and—”

“I’m not here for a fight, Ryan,” Mitch cut me off quietly and calmly. My tall, dark-haired work client looked at me, and I could see the determination in his eyes like he wasn’t about to take any shit. “I tried calling you but you weren’t picking up. I wanted to make sure you were okay.”

I froze for a second, surprised by his suddenly caring approach. I glanced down at my phone on the floor, still lying where I’d dropped it last night, and checked it. Two missed calls from him. He wasn’t lying, he’d been trying to get a hold of me. I sighed, rubbing my eyes. “What do you want?”

“Look,” Mitch continued, taking another step forward, concern in his eyes, “I’m here because I want to help. You’re clearly a mess, and I know why you’re pissed off with me and hit me. But I’m not here to start trouble, alright?”

His lip was bruised, cut in the corner. I wanted to lash out again, to scream at him, but part of me knew I had to let him speak. Mitch wasn't the problem right now. Hell, I wasn't sure who or what the problem even was anymore.

He looked around the house, his eyes taking in the disarray—the beer cans strewn across the room, the dishes piled up, the general neglect. He raised an eyebrow, his gaze softening for a moment as if he was silently judging me. I couldn't blame him.

"You need to sort your shit out, Ryan," he said, his tone blunt. "This isn't you. You're drowning, and everyone can see it. You're throwing everything away, including Emmie."

I clenched my jaw, resisting the urge to snap back. I knew he was right, but hearing someone say it out loud, especially *him*, made the truth hit a lot harder.

"She won't talk to me," I informed him. "It's not like I haven't tried. I think it's over. She's done with me."

"Well, yeah. It looks like you've pissed everyone off, not just Emmie," Mitch continued, looking around the room again. "So, I'm here because it looks like I'm the only one that can repair this fucking mess you've made. And I'm not just talking about your house. Oh... and I'm going to explain myself to you, alright? Just... let me talk."

I was tired. Tired of being angry, tired of spinning my wheels without any progress. I had no idea how to undo any of this, so I had nothing to lose. The only problem was the issue upstairs but I had time, if he didn't stay too long.

"Fine," I muttered, dropping my shoulders. "Talk."

Mitch sat down, looking at me like I was a wounded animal that he was trying to tame. "First off," he started, "I'm not proud of what happened with Emmie. I'm not. I'm not here to apologise for it, Ryan, but I want to explain. For you. For Emmie."

"Go ahead then. Explain," I shrugged, staying standing despite my tiredness and throbbing head.

Mitch ran a hand through his hair, those blue eyes of his considering me for a long moment before replying. "First of all, I didn't have sex with Emmie. We almost did, but it never went that far."

"She sucked your cock." I nodded. "I hope she was good. Did she swallow?"

“Stop being so bitter,” he replied, frowning and shaking his head. Then he sighed. “Look, this isn’t easy for me, but I’m going to tell you something. A secret. Since school, I’ve always liked Emmie. Maybe... maybe I was in love with her. That teenage kind of love. I guess it was. But whatever it was... is... I care about her. Always have.”

“So much so that as soon as we split up, you tried to move in on her?” I crossed my arms, glaring at him, still suspicious of his motives. Mitch had never tried to help me. All he’d ever done was be an asshole and a bully.

“It’s not like that.” He shook his head and sighed again. “You were the man Emmie chose. I asked her out. She said no. I asked her again and again but she always said no because she loved you. And because of how I felt about her, I had to accept it. I didn’t understand it, Ryan, but I accepted it. So maybe that’s why I’ve always been mean towards you. Maybe I’m angry. I’m certainly jealous. I don’t know what it is that you’ve got that I haven’t but whatever it is, Emmie loves you for it and I can’t change that. I learned that a long time ago.”

“You’re jealous?” I arched an eyebrow. My head was hurting even more. Mitch’s confession was surprising and... satisfying, but now really wasn’t the time. I needed him to hurry up, tell me what he needed to tell me and go.

“Don’t push it,” Mitch warned, then allowed himself a rueful smile. “Anyway, look, I want to come clean with you. When you split up, I kept my distance. I didn’t move in on her as you said. It wasn’t until I had a meeting with Ethan and he started to brag to me about what he’d gotten up to with her that I got involved.”

I didn’t say anything. I simply nodded for him to continue, letting him fill in the gaps in my knowledge.

“I’ve known Ethan for a long time. We’ve done business together and I don’t like the way he operates. In business, sure, he’s a savvy guy. He’s rich for a reason, but in his personal life? Nah.” Mitch wiped his mouth with the back of his hand in distaste, wincing as he caught the bruised cut. “He’s married, or at least, he was. He’s always had mistresses and his wife tolerated it for whatever reason, but when she found out that he’s been dating and sleeping with pornstars and not only that, but making his own little sordid porn movies with his lovers, she went crazy. Anyway, when he told me he’d been seeing Emmie, I got mad. I told her what he’s like and

she told me that, yeah, he'd been trying to get her to do things... make sex videos... and sleep with clients of his to secure new deals."

"He did what?" I was so stunned by that revelation that I dropped my phone for a second time, managing to soften the blow before it hit the ground by half-catching it with my bare foot.

"She refused," Mitch reassured me. "She made videos... which you know about, but she never let him pimp her out for business. In the end, I talked her into ending it with him. He wasn't happy. He'd cut off his previous mistress for her but that wasn't Emmie's fault. She realised she'd fallen into Ethan's trap and it wasn't going to be easy for her from now on, so she quit her job too."

"And she sucked your cock as thanks?" I knew I was being an asshole but I couldn't help myself.

"No. We came back here. She was upset and... yeah, I kind of took advantage. But that's all that happened, Ryan. She stopped it before it went any further and I realised I was being a jerk. After that, I spoke to Ethan and Nate, Emmie's biggest client and brokered a deal with them which ended up in Emmie getting a new job with Nate. I did all of this to protect her, Ryan. To protect both of you, in a way. Because when we... did what we did, the reason she stopped me... she told me she still loved you."

"You really expect me to believe all of that?" I said after a long moment. Mitch's face was open, sincere. He even looked... embarrassed, maybe. My gut told me he was telling me the truth but I needed to hear it from him.

"Yes, I do. You should believe it because it's true." He stood up and walked past me into the kitchen. I turned, watching as he pulled a plastic sack from the cupboard beneath the sink and then proceeded to busy himself around me, tidying up and tossing the empty beer bottles and cans into the bag. "Emmie talked to me a lot while you were apart. She told me how she missed you, how she'd spoken to her neighbours about you. How she realised she'd made a mistake ever letting you walk away. That couple next door talked her into giving you another chance. I told her the same. She loves you. Love is a rare thing, Ryan. It doesn't come around often, not the type of love you guys have. So sort your shit out. Get your head together. And let's figure this thing out."

"Have you spoken to Emmie?" I asked, picking up a dirty pair of socks and tossing them towards the bottom of the stairs. I'd take them upstairs and put them in the laundry basket once he'd gone. Which, hopefully, was

soon, before things... got even more complicated. "Because I don't think she wants me back."

"You don't know that. Yes, I've spoken to her. I gave it a couple of days, then called her to find out what the fuck was going on. Why you had the outburst, why you hit me. She didn't want to talk to me. In fact, she said I was the last person she wanted to speak to, but eventually, I got it out of her. About the emails. The videos. The blackmail. Last week, she called Ethan, Nate and I together. We had a meeting over drinks and the three of us agreed to do a deal with her sister, buying into the salon to help raise some funds for her. I didn't know why, at the time, but now that I do..." He finished collecting the empty bottles, tying up the full sack before beginning to straighten the cushions and rug. "I'm going to employ every resource at my disposal to find out who's behind it. And I already have my suspicions."

"You do?" My heart thudded in my chest. "Who?"

"I'm not ready to disclose that information yet." Mitch gazed around him, happy with the transformation of the room from a garbage dump to a neat and tidy living space once again. "First of all, we need to save your relationship. Which means you having a shower and a shave. You stink and look like a homeless guy. Get a fucking shave and make yourself presentable. Tonight, we're going out."

"Going out? Where?" This was all moving too fast. What was going on?

"There's no easy way of saying this," Mitch said, holding my gaze, his expression serious now. "Emmie's hurt. All the things she did while you were apart, the sex she had, was because she was hurting. She was confused, lost, lonely. And she's feeling the same way right now."

"I know that's why she did it." My legs felt weird. I was so tired. My brain hurt. I slumped down onto the sofa, even though I shouldn't. I needed Mitch to go. I was running out of time. "I don't like it but I can understand it. However, it hurts that she lied to me. She never said she'd been with anyone during our break, and when I found out... I got jealous, I guess,0 obsessed with knowing what happened and with who. I've fucked everything up, Mitch. And I have no idea what to do about it. She won't talk to me."

"Which is why I'm here." The tall, dark-haired man who'd been an asshole to me for almost my entire life walked over, grabbed my arm and

hauled me to my feet. “Ryan, we have to get you cleaned up and get you and Emmie together, before it’s too late.”

“Before it’s too late?” I stared over my shoulder at him as he ushered me towards the stairs. *Shit*. Did he know? “What do you mean?”

“The last guy she was seeing before you two got back together,” Mitch explained, pushing me up the first couple of steps before I stopped him. I couldn’t let him go up there. Downstairs was a mess but upstairs... “Was a guy from the gym. Craig, I think his name is. Anyway, he was serious about her, even though she only ever saw him as a distraction, a friend-with-benefits, call it what you will. He still likes her now and for whatever reason, she’s been talking to him, probably out of anger at you.”

“Talking to him?” My stomach lurched. I didn’t want to hear this.

“Just talking... as far as I know, that’s all,” Mitch reassured me, probably sensing the anxiety in my voice. “But she’s going out tonight... and if what Ollie has told Nate is correct, she’s meeting up with him.”

“No fucking way is that happening.” I sucked in a deep breath. Ollie told Nate, who told Mitch? How fucking complicated was this? “Where are they meeting? I won’t let her fuck him again, Mitch. I need to stop this. You said you can help. Tell me.”

“That’s why I’m here,” he replied, putting a hand on my shoulder and squeezing it firmly. “I can just about bear losing Emmie to you. But there’s no fucking way I’m going to lose her to some God damn fancy-haired gym rat. So get in the shower. Clean your stinking ass up and I’ll pick you up at eight. We’ll sort this shit out once and for all, and along the way, I’ll find out who’s screwed you and Jen over so I can get my damn money back. What am I going to do with a share in a hair salon?”

That comment brought a laugh from me, although it came out as more of a wheeze because my throat was so dry. “I’ll get myself cleaned up,” I promised him. We were on the stairs, talking loud. I needed him gone. Now. “You can go. I’ll be ready.”

“Make sure you are.” He wrinkled his nose. “And put some aftershave on. You really do smell like... I don’t know what you smell like. I’ll see you later.”

I knew what I smelled of. I watched him leave, then headed upstairs and walked into the bedroom, relief flooding through me. Laura shifted in bed, stretching her arms above her head, her body languid and lithe beneath the covers. Her curves were accentuated by the way the soft light from the

window hit her, and for a brief second, I was tempted to climb back in beside her.

"Who was that?" she asked, her voice lazy but curious, as she propped herself up on her elbows. Her hair was tousled, falling around her shoulders in fiery red waves. The white sheets slipped from her chest, and for a moment, I let myself enjoy the sight of her large, firm, round breasts.

It had been easy to get lost in her. After Kenji had gone home, she'd come over to see if I was okay and we'd just talked. I'd told her everything and she listened. Then we fucked. It had been a relief, at first, to have someone who didn't carry the complexity of relationships, who just wanted to fuck, and wasn't a part of the mess I was drowning in. Someone who made me forget, even if just for a few hours, about Emmie and everything I'd lost.

That was several days ago. She'd been over every day since. To talk. And fuck.

"That was Mitch," I said, my voice hoarse, feeling the truth of it all pressing down on me. "He's a work client... and an old friend. He's helping me with... all this. Emmie, the blackmail, everything."

Laura's expression softened, and she sat up a little straighter, her breasts swinging pleasantly, her eyes searching mine. "Are you okay?" she asked gently, though I could sense the hint of concern in her voice.

"I don't know," I muttered, my eyes dropping to the floor. "I'm a mess, aren't I? Drinking too much, doing... things I shouldn't." I paused, the weight of it all sinking in again. "I thought I'd lost Emmie for good. I thought it was over."

Laura didn't respond at first, just watched me, her gaze steady and understanding. She always understood, even when I didn't want her to.

"And now?" she asked quietly, her tone softer now.

"I don't know." I rubbed my temples, trying to clear the fog in my head. Mitch had given me a glimmer of hope, a way forward. Emmie wasn't lost, not yet. I was tangled in a web of my own making—of my relationships, of damaged friendships and an endangered career, but maybe he was right. Maybe I could disentangle myself. Get my life and my marriage back on track. "I think... I've been trying to distract myself with you. It wasn't right, Laura. I'm sorry. I'm grateful that you've been here for me, but I think I need to listen to Mitch. I need to try one more time to fix things with Emmie."

I felt the words hang in the air between us, the gravity of them more than I'd expected. Laura didn't flinch or react the way I thought she would. Instead, she just looked at me, a small sigh escaping her lips.

"I know," she said, her voice quiet but filled with understanding. "Don't worry. You needed to do this. You needed to forget about it for a while. I get it, Ryan. But we both know this can't go on forever. We knew what this was from the start. And I've enjoyed every moment."

I let out a shaky breath. She wasn't angry, wasn't pushing me away. She was being kind, something I wasn't used to in the mess of my life right now.

"I can't keep doing this to Emmie," I confessed, my voice tight. "I need to fix it. I need to find a way to make things right. I can't keep pretending this... whatever this is with you... is anything more than it is."

Laura didn't look hurt, though I could see the subtle change in her expression. She nodded slowly, and then, almost as if to comfort me, she reached for my hand. "Stop worrying, Ryan. I'm happy in my marriage with Mark. I don't want or expect anything more than this. I know you have to go fix things with Emmie and I'm glad. You're a good man, even if you don't always see it."

I looked down at her hand in mine, the softness of her touch grounding me for a moment. But I knew she was right. This had never been about her—it was about the gaping hole I was trying to fill, the absence of Emmie, the betrayal I'd felt when everything unravelled.

"Thank you," I said, leaning in and kissing her forehead.

Laura didn't respond at first, but then she put her hands to the back of my head, pulling me to her, her lips brushing against mine, warm and comforting. For a moment, I allowed myself to let go, to feel something other than the pain of the mess I'd made one more time. And for just that fleeting moment, I let myself be lost in the moment with her—no questions, no regrets, just the fleeting relief of an escape. She kicked the covers away, parting her thighs, showing me the shaved, wet pussy that I'd fucked dozens of times over the past few days.

I stripped off the sweaty T-shirt and shorts I'd worn since yesterday and lowered myself into her embrace. Her hand took my hard cock and guided it into her heat. It slid in easily, the feeling making me sigh in pleasure. Then her hands wrapped around my back and I began to fuck her, savouring

the wetness of her, the way her body responded, her thighs sliding over my hips to let me drive deeper into her.

We fucked, hard, passionately, our tongues entwining as we kissed. But as soon as it ended, my cock bursting inside her, filling her with cum for the umpteenth time, I pulled away.

“I should go clean up,” I said, my voice more controlled now. “Get my head straight so I’m ready for when Mitch picks me up. He’s going to take me to her. Give me a chance to work things out.”

Laura didn’t stop me as I stood up. She stretched again, fully naked, teasing me with the amazing curves of her body, my cum leaking from her pink slit. She really was okay with this.

“Your secret... *our* secret,” she said softly. “Don’t worry. It’s safe with me. Unless you *want* to tell Emmie, I’ll always keep this between us. Now go and take a shower. I need to head home anyway. Mark’s back tonight and we’ve got friends coming over for the barbecue this weekend.”

I nodded, grateful to Laura for everything. I was sure that she wasn’t the blackmailer. I’d also eliminated Luke and now Mitch. The list of suspects was narrowing and perhaps, with his help, I’d figure out who it was.

Laura got dressed and left, leaving me with another lingering kiss and then, as I walked into the bathroom, I looked at myself in the mirror. I hadn’t been this lost in a long time. But Mitch was right—I had to clean my act up, both physically and emotionally, and find myself. If I had any hope of getting Emmie back, I had to show her that I was sorry. That I was ready to make things right.

As I turned on the water and stepped into the shower, the only thing that mattered now was finding a way to save what was left of us. I wasn’t going to give Emmie up without a fight.

Chapter Six

The neon lights of Rapture hit me the second we stepped through the door. Green and purple neon lights flashed across the nightclub, casting shadows and vibrant glows over the throngs of people swaying to the pulsing beat of the music. The air inside Rapture was thick with the scent of sweat, perfume, and alcohol. The bass boomed through the floor and vibrated in my chest, a constant throb that seemed to match the frenetic rhythm of the crowd.

The interior was alive with dancing bodies pressed close together, some lost in the music, others laughing or shouting over the beat. Strobe lights flashed overhead, momentarily blinding me as they danced over the crowd like a chaotic wave of colour. The bar glowed with neon, casting everything in an otherworldly glow. It reminded me of the first time I'd stepped foot in this place, years ago, when Emmie and I were just starting to date. She loved this place—always had. She'd pull me onto the dance floor, laughing as she moved with the music, the lights flashing against her blonde hair as she danced. She was always so alive here, carefree, and somehow, I was never able to match her energy.

Mitch pushed past me, his eyes scanning the crowd. "She should be here already," he said, his voice barely audible over the booming sound. "If Nate's got it right, she should be somewhere around here. But with this crowd, we'll have to keep looking."

I nodded, the weight of everything pressing down on me again. "She's probably on the dancefloor," I muttered, more to myself than to Mitch.

Mitch glanced at me, but didn't comment on my words. He seemed distracted, pulling his phone out to check for a message. "I've tried calling her, but her phone's off," he said, frustration edging his tone. "Went by the gym earlier too, before I picked you up. It was closed. I don't know, man, but I'm starting to think we might be chasing shadows."

The club felt bigger than it had in the past, somehow. Maybe it was the anxiety, the excitement, of all the emotions swirling inside me. The strobe lights flashed again, casting everything in erratic shadows. The entire place seemed to pulse and vibrate in time with the bass, the crowded dance floor moving like a living thing, alive with energy but hollow at the same time. It was the kind of place where anything could happen and I had no idea what might happen, if we found Emmie.

I looked around, hoping to spot her, but there were too many people. Too many bodies moving in every direction. I wasn't sure what I'd do when I found her, but I needed to see her. I needed to know if what Mitch had said was true.

"We should just keep looking," I said, more to steady myself than anything. "She's here. She has to be. She loves this place. It's her go-to whenever she goes out."

Mitch took a deep breath and nodded, turning his attention back to the crowd. "Let's go," he said.

We moved through the club, weaving between clusters of people. My mind was a jumble, thinking about the conversation I'd have with Emmie when we found her, and about all the questions I still needed answers to. We climbed a long set of stairs and as we reached the balcony overlooking the heaving dance floor, Mitch stopped and leaned against the railing.

"Still don't see her," Mitch said, eyes scanning the crowd. He sounded more frustrated than before. He was trying to stay calm, but it was clear that the situation was starting to bother him more than he wanted to admit. Was he wrong about all of this?

"We're here now. We may as well keep looking," I said, though I didn't sound sure of myself. I wasn't even sure of anything anymore.

The music surged again, a shift in tempo, and I could see people dancing even more frenetically, lost in the rhythm. The whole place seemed to pulse with life, and yet, watching them, I felt more alone than I had in a long time.

Mitch sighed, putting his phone back in his pocket. “Let’s look from the other side of the balcony,” he said, his voice softening slightly. “Maybe we’ll see her from there.”

Mitch and I pushed our way through the crowd, reaching the far side of the crescent upstairs section. I looked over the balcony and finally, I saw her. Emmie. My heart sank as soon as my eyes landed on her. She was on the dance floor, her body pressed close to a muscular, well-dressed guy with perfectly-styled blond hair. He turned and I saw his face. It was Craig, the man I remembered from the gym, talking to T.J.

Flashing lights painted her skin in bright purple strokes, the crowd parting around her for a moment like waves crashing against a cliff, almost like I willed them to move aside. She was wearing her leather biker jacket that barely concealed her black bra top, showcasing so much of her large cleavage that my throat tightened with a mixture of frustration and, oddly, something else. My eyes were drawn to her—of course they were—but I hated that she was standing there with him, moving to the music, smiling up at him in a way I hadn’t seen her do for me in days.

“Let’s go,” I muttered, barely able to control the edge in my voice.

Mitch nodded, he’d seen her too, but before we could move, the balcony started to crowd, blocking us from moving temporarily. I stared back down at Emmie, unable to take my eyes off her. Craig’s hands were moving lower on her back, and she leaned into him, her face flushed from the heat of the lights and the press of bodies around her. And then, to my shock, Craig moved in closer and kissed her.

It was a soft kiss at first, but the second it happened, the world around me seemed to freeze. A rush of hurt flared up in my chest, but alongside it, something else—something dark and unfamiliar—flared to life too. I felt a tightness in my jeans, the unexpected flush of arousal that I couldn’t shake. He had his hands on her ass, feeling her curves through the tight black pants she was wearing. This was happening. It made me sick, but it also... stirred something in me. I forced the emotion down, telling myself that I wasn’t here for this. I wasn’t here to get lost in jealousy or anger. I needed to talk to her. I needed to stop her before she made a mistake.

“We need to get down there,” I said, my voice firmer now. I couldn’t stand watching this, couldn’t stand knowing that she was in Craig’s arms like this. I had to get to her.

Mitch, sensing my frustration, put a hand on my shoulder. “Pay no heed to the kiss, Ryan,” he said, his voice surprisingly calm, though his eyes were searching the scene too. “She’s probably drunk or angry, or a mixture of both. Don’t let it get to you.”

But how could I not? How could I watch the woman I loved kiss another man, especially someone she’d already had a history with? It wasn’t just the kiss. It was the intimacy in the way they moved together, the way he held her. I had to stop it.

We managed to push through the crowd, jostling our way to the stairs that led to the dance floor. The music was loud, and the heat from the bodies around us made the air hot and overwhelming. I tried to keep an eye on the dance floor, noting where we’d seen them but when we got there, she was gone.

I cursed under my breath. She’d moved. Mitch squeezed through the crowd, his eyes scanning the room.

“Where the hell did she go?” I muttered.

“She couldn’t have gone far,” Mitch said. He was still calm, but I could feel the tension in his shoulders as he looked around. “You head left. I’ll go right. We’ll find her. Meet at the bar, yeah?”

I nodded and then I pushed further, turning right, heading toward the darker, quieter corner. At first, there was no sign of her but just as I was about to give up and head to the bar to meet Mitch, I saw her. Emmie. She was standing in a darkened corner of the club, her back pressed up against the wall. Craig was with her again, this time more aggressive. His hands were all over her, gripping her waist, pulling her closer.

Moving through the crowd, I could only watch in disbelief as his hands slid beneath the open leather jacket, moving over her chest, cupping her breasts through the tiny bra top. Emmie didn’t pull away. She didn’t push him off. Instead, she leaned into him, her lips meeting his once again in a kiss that was deeper, more intense than before.

The room felt like it was spinning, even though I hadn’t had a drink. This wasn’t right. Emmie wasn’t the type of woman to let this happen. This was a mistake. She was angry, confused—she had to be. The crowd seemed to close in, pushing and shoving, blocking me from getting any closer. The music was louder now, the strobe lights flashing erratically, making it feel like I was in slow motion as I made my way towards them. Every time I thought I was almost there, another group would step into my path.

Time stretched on, each second dragging until I finally broke free of the crowd and saw Emmie again, her head tilted back, her lips pressed against Craig's, but this time, his hands were lower. I watched in disbelief as Craig's hand slipped beneath the waistband of her tight black bottoms, his fingers making their way between her legs. And then I saw that she was massaging his cock through his trousers, her hand moving up and down, feeling him.

I froze. The sight made my heart pound in my chest, but at the same time, something gave way inside me, a grip on me that I couldn't shake. The anger, the jealousy... and a strange, confusing stir of arousal that disgusted me. Why the hell was I feeling like this? Was it the way they were teaching each other? Was it just the frustration of seeing her with him?

"Stay calm," Mitch said, his voice low, as if sensing my internal conflict. He'd caught up with me and spotted Emmie and Craig. I realised I'd been standing there for a while, watching them. What was wrong with me? Why didn't I go over there and stop them?

Mitch's hand landed on my shoulder, a firm but steadying grip. "She's just angry, mate. Don't let it get to you. They're only fooling around. Let's go talk to them."

I finally made myself walk into the darkened area, Mitch following me. Craig was still fumbling inside her pants, his face tilted toward her as he whispered something in her ear. They were too wrapped up in each other to notice us until we were right in front of them.

"Emmie," I said, my voice hard, though my body was still thrumming with anger. "What are you doing?"

She broke away from Craig at the sound of my voice, her wide eyes locking onto me as she pulled his hand from down her bottoms. Her shock was evident, and for a moment, she just stared at me, mouth slightly open. But then her gaze flicked to Mitch standing next to me, and the shock turned into something else—something I couldn't read.

"Ryan," she said, her voice shaky as she shouted over the top of the pulsating music. "What the fuck are you doing here? And... and why the hell is Mitch with you?"

I could hear the defensiveness in her tone, but it only made me angrier. Was she seriously going to act like nothing was wrong here?

"Don't make this worse, Emmie," I said, my voice strained. "We need to talk. Now. You're not doing this. Not here, not like this."

Craig stepped in, his hand moving to Emmie's waist as if to shield her from me. "Hey, man, chill," he said, looking bemused but not quite stepping back. "She's just having a night out with her friend. No need to get all worked up."

I looked at Craig, my jaw tightening. "Friend?" I scoffed. "That's my wife you're trying to finger-fuck."

"Wife? Yeah, well, from what Emmie's told me, you've been an asshole," Craig shot back, clearly not intimidated.

"I admit it," I said, stepping closer to him. "I'm an asshole. But I don't need you messing with my wife. Now do yourself a favour and fuck off."

Craig didn't back down. His chest puffed out, and for a second, I thought he might get physical. "What, you think just because you're her husband, you can just come here and tell me what to do? She's her own woman."

"Yeah," I snapped, "and I'm my own man. And I'm saying you don't get to touch her."

Craig walked towards me, stopping inches away. His chest puffed up as he leaned in slightly, trying to intimidate me with his broad stance, his eyes narrowing in annoyance but I stood firm, my feet planted on the floor, my gaze locked onto Craig's. He was taller, broader than me, muscular and athletic but I wasn't about to back down.

"You think just because you're here with your buddy, you can talk to me like that?" Craig sneered, his voice low but full of menace. "Who the fuck do you think you are?"

Emmie stepped forward then, her voice cutting through the thick air. "Both of you, stop," she said, looking between us. She was breathing hard, her hands balled into fists at her sides. "Craig, leave it. Ryan, just go. I don't want to talk to you right now."

My fists were clenched, but I was holding back, trying not to lose control. I didn't flinch. I wasn't going to let this gym rat push me around. Emmie wasn't just some woman for him to toy with. She was mine.

"I don't care what your deal is, Craig," I said, ignoring Emmie, my voice controlled, trying to hide the fact that I was shaking slightly. "She's my wife. This is your last warning. Back the fuck off."

For a long moment, we stood there, glaring at each other over Emmie's head. Neither of us was willing to back down. I could hear the music pounding around us, the strobe lights flashing, but it all faded away except

for the tension in the air between us. Finally, Craig let out a deep sigh and stepped back slightly, his hands raised in mock surrender.

“You know what,” Craig muttered, irritation thick in his voice. “This isn’t worth the aggro. You two have got your issues, I’ve got mine. So whatever, I’m done.”

He turned to leave, but Emmie’s voice stopped him mid-step.

“You’re just going to leave like that?” she asked, her voice sharp, a mix of frustration and confusion. “After everything we’ve talked about?”

Craig turned back to face her, his expression softening just a little, but there was still that distance in his eyes. “Look, Emmie, I didn’t ask for any of this,” he said, his tone almost apologetic now. “But I’m not sticking around to get in the middle of your mess. When you’ve sorted your shit out, get in touch. Enjoy your night.”

With that, he turned and walked away, melting back into the crowd. Emmie stood there, her eyes following him for a moment, before her shoulders slumped in defeat. She sighed deeply, then rounded on me, a blaze of anger in her gaze now.

Mitch, seeing how upset she was, placed a hand on her shoulder quickly, giving it a gentle squeeze. I was grateful that he’d stayed out of it so far. “You’ve got to talk to him, Emmie,” Mitch said, his voice quiet but firm. “You need to sort this out with Ryan. The longer you keep running, the harder it’s going to be for both of you..”

She looked at me, her eyes still furious. “Why are you even here? I told you I don’t want to talk to you. You tricked Jen. You kept the videos.”

“That’s not what happened.” I shook my head. “I gave Jen the videos but the blackmailer sent copies to my email. I can show you.”

Emmie’s eyes narrowed. Didn’t she believe me?

“Emmie, I don’t care about the things you did while we were apart,” I said, my voice steady, though I could feel the rawness behind it. “I don’t care about the videos, or the people you had sex with. You’re right. Those things happened while we were apart, I can accept that now. I’m angry that you lied to me about it but what matters now is that I love you. And I think you love me too. We have a marriage, and I’m not giving up on it.”

Emmie’s breath caught in her throat, and I could see her trying to hold it together, but the walls she’d built around herself were crumbling. Slowly, her hand reached out, unsure at first, but then steady.

“We should at least talk about it,” I said, my words softening. “I know I’ve been an asshole. I shouldn’t have watched the videos. I should’ve trusted you, Emmie. The emailer sent me those videos and I was tempted. I wanted to know what was on them, but I shouldn’t have looked. I fucked up.”

The silence stretched between us. The noise of the club—the flashing lights, the thumping music—faded into the background as I waited for her to say something. Anything.

“I’m sorry, Emmie,” I said, the sincerity in my voice cutting through the noise. “From the bottom of my heart, I’m sorry. I understand now why you and Jen did everything you could to keep those secrets from me. I get it now. If you’re still angry at me, if you don’t want to be with me any more, I get it. I lied to you. You lied to me. But we can’t leave it like this.”

Emmie blinked, and I saw tears building up in her eyes. “I didn’t want to hurt you,” she whispered, her voice soft and vulnerable. “But when we got together... I didn’t know how to tell you what I’d done. And the videos... I didn’t want you to see that side of me. It wasn’t who I wanted to be anymore.”

Mitch looked at Emmie, then at me, his expression serious. “I’m going to find the person who’s been blackmailing Jen,” he said, his voice low but determined. “I’ll make sure the videos are destroyed. Jen will get her salon back, and we’ll get the money back from the blackmailer. I’ve got a few ideas of who it could be, but... we’ll get there. For now, just be patient.”

As Mitch spoke, I couldn’t help but notice how he was sneaking glances at Emmie. I didn’t blame him—hell, I understood. She looked incredible tonight. The tight black bra top didn’t hide much. The inner slopes of her breasts were on full display between the lapels of her leather jacket. It wasn’t jealousy I felt exactly—it was more of a complicated mess of emotions. She was mine, but Mitch wasn’t blind. I wasn’t the only one who noticed how stunning she looked.

We moved from the dark corner to the bar, getting three shots, which we downed together before buying three beers, which we took to a nearby booth, away from the throngs of people. Mitch slid in first, motioning for Emmie and me to join him. I sat across from her, but it wasn’t lost on me how close she was. I could feel the heat of her skin from the side of the booth, the soft scent of her perfume still lingering in the air between us. I

focused on the drink in front of me, willing myself not to be consumed by everything that had happened.

Emmie took a deep breath and exhaled slowly, her eyes lingering on her drink before she looked up at Mitch and me. “I shouldn’t be drinking. I’m already drunk,” she said softly, her voice tinged with self-deprecation. “I’m not going to apologise, you know? For... Craig.”

Her words hit me like a slap to the face. I hadn’t expected that. I didn’t know what I expected, but definitely not this. She looked at me now, her eyes softer, a quiet sadness behind them. “I’m angry. Maybe I’m lashing out. Trying to convince myself that losing you isn’t the end of the world.”

I could hear the guilt in her voice, but also something else—something raw. Self-awareness.

She took another sip of her drink and continued, her voice quieter now. “I like to be in control. Back in school, in college, I liked having both of you chasing me. I played you off against each other. I’m sorry. But when I lose control... I’m capable of self-destructive behaviour. I always have been. It’s what I did when you left. I tried to control you, to make you come back but you wouldn’t. So I did what I did. I was looking for a way to make myself feel better, to move on. To take control back.”

She might be drunk but she was making sense. “You’re not the only one who’s fucked up, Emmie,” I said quietly, my voice softer than I intended. “I’ve made plenty of mistakes too. But now, I don’t care what you did while we were apart. It doesn’t matter to me anymore.”

She looked at me, her eyes searching mine. “You don’t care?” she asked softly, almost like she didn’t believe me.

“I just can’t believe you lied to me,” I replied, suddenly unwilling to simply forgive and move on. “When I found those condoms, you should have told me. You should have trusted me to understand.”

When Emmie didn’t reply, instead staring at her drink for a long moment, Mitch glanced between the two of us, his expression unreadable., then finished his beer with a long gulp, setting the glass down on the table with a soft thud. He stood up, brushing off his jacket and glancing at us both. “I’ll leave you two to talk,” Mitch said, his tone softer than it had been when he first arrived. “I don’t think I can be your mediator all night. But listen. I’ll be back tomorrow. We’ve got a blackmailer to catch.” He gave me a quick look, then turned to Emmie. “You’ll be okay?”

Emmie nodded, offering him a small, tired smile. "I'm fine, Mitch. Thanks."

He gave a short nod before turning to leave, his tall frame disappearing into the crowd. The noise from the dance floor seemed louder now, but it didn't matter. It was just me and Emmie. And I needed to hear everything—whatever she was willing to tell me.

For a moment, neither of us spoke. I couldn't seem to find the right words. I'd been so consumed by jealousy, frustration, and anger. But now, sitting here with her, I realized how much I had missed her voice, the way she looked when she was telling me the truth. I had to know everything. We had to clear the air, once and for all. Even if it destroyed us.

"Emmie," I said quietly, leaning in slightly, "I need you to tell me. Everything. Don't leave anything out."

She sighed, looking down at her drink, her fingers tracing the rim of her glass absentmindedly. Her voice was small but steady when she spoke again.

"I don't know where to start," she murmured. "I guess... it's not easy to talk about."

I waited, not interrupting, giving her the space to speak. She looked at me, and for the first time in what felt like forever, I saw vulnerability in her eyes. But then just as quickly, the anger came back. She was conflicted, like I was.

"It started with Max," she said, her voice soft but tinged with regret. "You know how it happened. I know Jen told you. I was drunk and horny and that's all it was. Just sex. A one-night stand. Of course, it ended up becoming more than that. The foursome. We were both drunk, Jen and me. I didn't know what I was doing. I was trying to get over you, trying to fill the hole in me. Trying to have fun and it went too far."

I didn't speak. I just nodded, letting her keep talking.

"And then there was Ethan," she said, her voice dropping slightly, as though the name itself brought back uncomfortable memories. "He... seduced me. At first it was fun. He's good in bed. He's rich, always talking about all the things he could offer me, the opportunities, the business deals. He promised me things, and I... I thought 'why not?' But then he pushed me too far. He wanted me to make sex tapes for his clients, wanted me to sleep with them to secure deals. That was when I knew I had to get away from him. I couldn't do it, Ryan. I didn't want to be that person. Mitch talked me

into quitting the job. He helped me get a new job with Nate... and then you know what happened between him and me. We didn't fuck. We just..."

I exhaled slowly, interrupting her. "Mitch told me," I said, my voice low but sincere. "I feel for punching him but I thought you'd fucked him."

She hesitated before answering. "He's always cared about me. You know that. But when I was at my lowest, he was the one who was there for me. I sucked his cock and instantly regretted it. It's not that I don't find him attractive. Any woman would. I've just always kept him at a distance because... I didn't want to hurt you."

"And Craig?" I asked softly, dreading the answer, but knowing I needed to hear it.

Her eyes flickered, and she hesitated before speaking again. "Craig... happened one night at the gym. I wasn't looking for anything. He made a move on me, and I... fancied him. I thought you and I were through. You still hadn't tried to get back at that point, so I thought... fuck it. Why shouldn't I have some fun? I have needs, you know? So I fucked him in the gym after closing. Then he became a regular thing. He's good in bed, I'm sorry, but he is."

I could feel the pulse in my temple. I wish I'd punched him earlier when I had the chance. I took a long drink of my beer, trying to quell the urge to throw the glass across the room.

"You said you wanted honesty," Emmie said, her eyes boring into mine, sensing my rage. "I'm sorry if that was hard to hear. But, believe me, I never saw Craig as anything more than some fun. A fuck buddy, I guess." She paused, her face flushed with embarrassment. "I don't want you to think it means anything, Ryan. It didn't. He likes me, but I never felt anything like that for him. If I'm honest, I was using him tonight. Using him to get over you."

I just nodded. What could I say? The honesty in her voice was cutting through me, and for once, I didn't feel like I needed to judge her. For some reason, the thought of her and Craig... fucking in the gym... with his athletic physique and Emmie's natural fitness, it was hard not to imagine them going at it, raw, passionate sex. And the thought turned me on. I couldn't shake the image of Craig with his hands all over her, how she'd let him finger her, rubbed his cock, right here, in the club, in public. And it stirred something in me I couldn't quite suppress—an anger, yes, but also an unrelenting desire to have her. And that made me angry with myself.

I looked up and saw Emmie watching me. There was a look in her hazel eyes that I recognised. She was horny too. Had recounting the details of her lovers turned her on?

“Are you done?” I asked, my voice tight, trying to keep my emotions in check, trying not to give in to the temptation to let everything she’d done just slide. “Done with all the lying? Done with all the secrets?”

Her expression darkened, and for a moment, I thought she might push back, but instead, she just exhaled sharply and stood up. She paced a couple of steps away, her jacket moving with each stride, and I could see how tense she was, how her fists clenched at her sides.

“I’m hot,” she said, her voice quiet but sharp, like she was trying to hold herself together. “I need some fresh air. Are you coming? We can talk more outside.”

I stood up, too, my legs stiff from sitting and followed her through the flashing neon lights, pushing through the crowd again until we slipped out of the back door and onto a small patio behind the club. The night air made me shiver as I followed Emmie into a back alley, away from the club's pounding beats and flashing lights. It was quieter here, the sound of the music muffled by the brick walls and the shadows that seemed to swallow us whole. The dim street lights flickered overhead, casting long shadows across the cracked pavement.

Emmie led the way, her heels clicking sharply against the ground, until she stopped at the far end of the alley, where the light was weakest, and turned to face me. I could barely make out the shape of her, but I could see her hazel eyes glinting in the darkness.

“Do you remember this place?” she asked softly, her voice tinged with something I couldn’t quite place—nostalgia, maybe? “Do you remember when we came here before, when we were just... young, carefree, not a care in the world?”

I took a slow breath, the memory hitting me harder than I expected. The place where we first kissed, where everything felt new and exciting. Back when we were just two people who hadn’t yet made mistakes, hadn’t hurt each other. Back when I could look at her and feel only hope.

“Yeah,” I said quietly, my voice almost a whisper. “I remember. We’d been in the club and I brought you back here...”

“You wanted to fuck me,” she giggled, wiping away a tear from her eye. I wanted to hold her but I didn’t. I let her talk. “But I stopped you. I made

you wait.”

I looked at her—really looked at her—and I realized how much had changed since those days. Back then, it had all been so simple. We had everything ahead of us. Now, it felt like we were just holding on by a thread.

“I miss those days,” she said, almost as if to herself. “I miss us, Ryan. I miss how easy it was. I miss not knowing that everything could fall apart.”

My heart ached for her, for us. We’d both done things—hurt each other in ways that couldn’t be undone. And as much as I wanted to reach out and pull her back into my arms, I couldn’t shake the doubt creeping in. I’d come here with such purpose, but now...

“You really wanted Craig tonight, didn’t you?” I asked, the words slipping out before I could stop them.

She sighed, rubbing her temples like she was trying to clear the fog in her mind. “Ryan, I fucked him last night. I’m sorry. I don’t know why I did it, Ryan. I really don’t. I just... I needed to feel something. Anything. And now I’m here, standing in front of you, and I don’t even know what to feel anymore. I feel bad for what I did with him, but it’s more than that. It’s like I’m questioning everything now. Questioning us. If we’re even meant to be together.”

Her words hit me harder than I expected. It felt like everything I had been holding onto, everything I had tried to rebuild between us, was slowly crumbling in front of me.

“You already fucked him?” I asked, my voice low, barely a whisper. “Shit. You really think it’s too late for us?”

“Yes, I did,” she said, her voice breaking just a little. “I wanted us to be okay, Ryan. I really did. But now... I feel like we’re too broken. That everything we’ve been through has left us so damaged that we can’t fix it.”

The sadness in her voice was so raw, it made me feel sick. I wanted to tell her it was all going to be fine, that we could still make it work. But deep down, I didn’t know. I didn’t know if we could fix this.

“I fucked up too. I let my jealousy, my obsession with the videos, drive a wedge between us. I didn’t trust you. I didn’t trust myself.” She fucked Craig. Should I tell her about Laura?

Before I could decide, she shook her head, her eyes glistening with unshed tears. “It’s not just about that, Ryan. It’s not just about the mistakes. It’s about who we are now. We’re not the same people we were. And maybe

we're not meant to be together anymore. Maybe we're just holding on to something that doesn't exist anymore."

Her words were a knife to the heart, and I didn't know how to respond. I didn't want to lose her. But everything had become so complicated, so tangled up in guilt and shame and anger.

"I don't want to lose you," I said, my voice barely above a whisper.

"I don't either," she replied, her voice catching, then she stepped closer, her face inches away, her hazel eyes searching mine. Then she dropped to her knees, shedding her leather jacket.

"What are you doing?" I hissed but she didn't stop, pulling her breasts free from the bra top and then fumbling at my zipper, undoing it and pulling out my cock, which was already erect for some reason.

"I'm doing what you wanted me to do all those years ago." She smiled up at me, a sad smile, then took me in her mouth. The warmth of her lips around my cock made my legs weaken and I had to lean back against the stone wall to steady myself. Emmie shuffled closer, her knees between my feet, gripping my shaft while working the head with her tongue.

"Fuck..." I gasped. "Emmie. We shouldn't..."

"Tell me," she murmured around me, then took me from her mouth for a second, gazing up at me, curiosity in her eyes. "And be honest. Did you enjoy watching me in those videos? Did you wank off to them?"

"I... Fuck, yes," I admitted, moaning as she sucked me again, her free hand tugging down my jeans, exposing me from the waist down to the cool autumnal air. Her mouth felt so good.

"Do you think I'm a slut?" she asked next. "And Jen? For what we did with Ethan? He offered us so much money... We couldn't say no. How do you think I kept up with the bills, the mortgage, while you were paying for your flat?"

"I don't know what I thought," I replied through gritted teeth, trying not to cum in her mouth. Why was I so fucking turned on? "I just watched it. And saw you with the black guy too."

"That was Ethan's idea." Emmie stood up suddenly, pulling her down her tight black bottoms and turning away from me, leaning against the wall opposite. "I enjoyed it but I don't know... That was the beginning of the end for me and him. Now fuck me, Ryan. Shut up and fuck me."

I did as she asked, stepping forward and pulling her black thong to one side. Her pussy was already so wet that when I levelled my cock and thrust

into her, it slid inside with no resistance. I took hold of her hips, not caring about the fact that anyone walking down this alleyway would see us, see everything as I began to fuck her. I was half-naked, Emmie the same, her tits tangling beneath her, swaying with the rhythm of my thrusts as I fucked her.

“Cum inside me,” she moaned. I could feel her fingers between her legs, rubbing against my shaft as she played with her clit. The realisation hit me that Craig’s fingers had been where my dick was just half an hour earlier, followed by the thought that his cock had too, last night. I wondered if he’d finished inside her as well.

“Where did Craig cum?” I found myself asking as I fucked her, harder and faster, my climax close. “Last night. Did you really fuck him?”

“Yes,” she moaned, “We used a condom. But you don’t have to. Just fuck me. Don’t stop. I’m close.”

I rammed myself into her, pulling her onto me by her hips, enjoying the sound of my balls slapping against her, her tits slapping together, the urgent moans escaping her lips, followed by the louder cry as she came. The feeling of her quivering against me drove me over the edge too, my cum spilling from me, deep inside her, then oozing out as I stepped back on unsteady legs.

In silence, we tidied ourselves up and as Emmie finished, donning her jacket once more, she looked at me, uncertainty in her eyes. I could read her feelings. I knew she was thinking the same thing as me, the sensations, the overwhelming sadness between us. That sex had felt like... a *for-old-times-sake* fuck. A *one-last-time* fuck. A goodbye, of sorts. I hoped it wasn’t. She’d kept things from me. Lied to my face. But for some reason, I still couldn’t deny the desire I felt for her. But was that all it was, desire?

Emmie took a deep breath, looking away from me for a moment, as if gathering her thoughts. She tugged her jacket tighter around her shoulders, almost as if trying to shield herself from what needed to be said.

“I should head home,” she said softly, her voice quiet and steady. “Back to Jen’s. You should go home, too. We need space, Ryan. We can talk more, but... if I’m honest, I think getting back together probably isn’t the right thing for either of us. I can tell you think the same.”

I nodded, the words sticking in my throat, the silence between us thickening. Part of me wanted to argue, wanted to tell her we could fix this, that we could try again. But the other part of me knew she was right. Things

were too complicated. There were too many layers of hurt, of deception, of broken trust.

“I get it,” I said finally, my voice low. “I guess you’re right... Will you be okay?”

She looked at me then, her eyes soft but full of uncertainty. “I will. You will too,” she whispered, then hesitated before speaking again. “Listen... Mitch has a plan. He didn’t want to share it with you, Ryan. He thought you’d overreact, do something crazy, but... I think you should know so you’re prepared for whatever he’s got set up for tomorrow. He’s convinced that the videos were hacked from Ethan’s PC. The only way that could have happened is when he had it repaired. I helped him with that. The person I gave it to for repair... Mitch thinks they’re the ones who did it.”

I froze. “Who?” I asked, the urgency in my voice obvious. “Who did you give the PC to?”

Emmie bit her lip, hesitating for a moment before answering. “Craig. That’s part of the reason I’ve been getting close to him this week.” She blushed and before I could ask the question, she answered it. “No, it’s not the only reason. I’m sorry. I did want... some fun.”

I swallowed down the sudden pain that admission caused and cleared my throat. “So Craig’s the one behind this? That doesn’t seem right. Why would he?”

“No, I don’t think so,” she shook her head, her blonde hair tumbling over one shoulder. “Not Craig. But Mitch thinks he knows who’s behind all of this. There’s more to it, he’s got more suspicions but he’s convinced that’s where we need to look. Whoever repaired Ethan’s PC stole the videos.”

Chapter Seven

It was an icy-cold morning but my palms were sweating as I followed Emmie and Jen. Mitch was ahead of us, walking with purpose, his hands shoved deep in the pockets of his jacket. The gravity of this moment felt like a weight on my shoulders—this was it. We were about to discover the person behind the blackmail, and the question still gnawed at me: Who was it?

We'd arranged to meet Helen first. She had key information for us and she was already waiting at the entrance to the office building when we arrived, her heels clicking against the polished floor as she came to greet us. I couldn't help but notice the way she stood—strong, composed, even in the face of all that had happened. She'd always been professional, a pillar of control, but today, there was something in her eyes that I hadn't seen before.

"Ryan," she greeted, offering me a slight smile. "Emmie, Jen. Mitch. Nice to see you, even if it's in these difficult circumstances."

We nodded in return, exchanging pleasantries, but I could tell everyone was just as on edge as I was. This was the culmination of everything—the end of a mystery that had twisted my life into knots for far too long.

"Are you sure about this?" Mitch asked, his voice low, his jaw set tight.

Helen gave him a reassuring nod, though her lips pressed into a thin line. "Everything we expected to be there is present, Mitch. The evidence is irrefutable."

I wasn't sure exactly what they were talking about, but the tone in their voices told me this wasn't just a casual chat. This was going to be a

confrontation, and I needed to stay calm. Mitch turned to me, his gaze sharp.

“Stay quiet, Ryan. Don’t overreact to anything you hear. We need to handle this carefully, or we’ll lose everything.”

I nodded, though my heart pounded in my chest. A storm was brewing inside me, but I pushed it down. I needed to be strong.

We moved toward the elevator, and I couldn't help but admire Helen and Mitch in the reflection of the polished metal doors. Mitch’s broad shoulders and dark, well-tailored grey suit contrasted sharply with Helen’s sleek, fitted navy dress. She looked stunning, her thick, brunette hair tied into a perfect bun, though her eyes had a tired, heavy look to them. She was an attractive woman, even though she was much older than me.

The elevator doors closed, and we ascended in tense silence. I kept my eyes on the floor, trying to calm myself, trying to figure out what was going on. What was about to happen?

When the elevator dinged, we exited onto the office floor. The first thing that caught my eye was Sophie’s empty office. Her desk, once cluttered with paperwork and knick-knacks, was bare. No personal effects, no laptop. Just an empty chair where she’d once sat.

Sophie’s absence was jarring and I realised that despite her often clumsy attempts at hitting on me, I’d miss her. When she wanted to be, she’d been funny, charismatic. Enigmatic too, with her brightly coloured hair and piercings, and I briefly wished that I’d gotten to know her better. But I couldn’t focus on that now. I pushed the thought aside, telling myself that what mattered was the task at hand.

We moved down the hall, passing a few desks with employees who glanced up but didn’t say anything. Finally, we reached the area where T.J. was sitting, hunched over a desk, repairing a PC for a young starter. She was a platinum blonde teenager with a slim, attractive body, her ponytail swishing as she shifted in her seat. I caught myself for a second, thinking of how she reminded me of a young Emmie, but forced the thought away.

“Hey, T.J.,” Mitch said, his voice smooth, though there was an edge to it.

T.J. glanced up, startled, before standing up. “What’s going on?” he asked, defensive, as though he knew something was wrong but wasn’t sure what. He must be wondering why I was there, despite being suspended, along with Emmie and Jen. He must know.

“You’re coming with us,” Mitch replied, his tone hardening. “Helen needs to speak with you.”

The young blonde’s eyes flickered between us, clearly sensing the tension, but she didn’t say anything. T.J. followed Mitch and Helen down the hall, with me and the girls trailing behind.

As we entered Helen’s office, my heart was thumping in my chest. What did T.J. have to do with this? The tech-whizz stood in front of us, his back stiff. Mitch closed the door behind us, locking it with a small click that was deafening in the silence.

Helen wasted no time. “T.J., we know what you’ve done. We know you’re the one who blackmailed Jen and sent those emails to Ryan. Don’t deny it.”

T.J. blanched, his brown eyes blinking rapidly with disbelief, or guilt. “I didn’t—I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

Wait. T.J. was the blackmailer? But... how? It didn’t make sense.

Helen placed a file on the desk in front of him, her eyes never leaving his. “We have all the evidence. Yesterday, I had H.R. do a sweep of your PC. We found a secret folder with screenshots of emails, copies of the videos, everything you’ve done. Don’t lie to me.”

T.J.’s face twisted in anger. “You did what? Is that even legal? This is ridiculous.”

“I’ll tell you what isn’t legal,” I couldn’t help myself, taking a threatening step towards him before Mitch grabbed me, pushing me back. “Blackmailing people isn’t legal.”

“Ryan, let me deal with this,” Helen chastised me as Mitch silenced me with a look. I glanced at Emmie and Jen who were staring at me and shaking their heads.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about,” T.J. insisted, folding his arms across his chest. “I need legal representation or something. I’m not talking until I have someone with me.”

“You repaired a computer, given to you by your friend, Craig, who in turn had been asked for help by Emmie,” Mitch explained. “On that computer were numerous videos. You stole them and then used them to blackmail Jen. Where is the money, T.J.?”

“What? I don’t have any money,” he spat. “Look... Shit, okay, I found some videos. I watched a couple of them out of curiosity. That’s all. I was shocked to see that it was Emmie. And Jen. But I didn’t blackmail anyone. I

didn't keep copies of the videos so I don't know they got on my PC. And I don't know what emails or screenshots you're talking about."

Helen's voice grew colder. "I don't like repeating myself but it appears I must. The videos were on your computer, T.J. The ones you took off Ethan's PC when you fixed it. And those screenshots of the emails? We know they came from you. Ryan says they came from a temporary email address each time. That's something only an I.T. expert like you would think to do."

T.J. looked away, his chest heaving with frustration. "You don't understand. I didn't blackmail anyone. I didn't take any money. I'm not that kind of guy."

"Really?" Mitch asked, leaning in. "So, what? Someone planted the evidence on your PC, and you never noticed? Even though you're an I.T. guy? You expect us to believe that?"

"You're done here," Helen said softly. "You're fired. Security will escort you out now. Then a legal team will be in touch to negotiate the return of what you've stolen from Jen."

The room froze as T.J. stood there, his face flushed with rage and embarrassment. "I didn't—this is bullshit!" he shouted, "Fuck you and your job. I quit." He turned on his heel and stormed out of the office without another word, slamming the door hard enough to crack the glass.

Helen's eyes followed him, her expression unreadable, ignoring the shattered glass. She sat, leaned back in her chair, and exhaled slowly. "He's lucky you don't want to go to the police," she muttered under her breath.

My thoughts were spinning as I tried to process everything. T.J. was the mastermind behind everything. He'd lied, played us for fools, stolen Jen's money, and now he had to deal with the consequences. He'd been a friend but now I felt nothing.

"Is it over?" Jen's voice was barely a whisper, fragile, almost like she was afraid to ask.

Mitch nodded firmly. "It's not over, no," he said, his eyes on Emmie, his face a mask of calm. "We'll still need to follow this up legally, make sure we have all our ducks in a row as we try to get the money back and make sure he's deleted any copies he has of the videos. But for now, at least, the blackmail, the leaking of the videos, is over."

I heard the words, but I couldn't help feeling like there was no victory in this. Not really. We'd all lost something important. Jen had lost her

business, Emmie and I had lost each other. Mitch and Helen had to deal with the fallout of it all. Those two were talking quietly, reassuring the girls, while I stood there, trying to make sense of everything .

I looked at Emmie, hoping for some kind of acknowledgment, but she wouldn't meet my eyes. Hers were fixed on the window, like she couldn't even bear to face me after everything that had happened.

"I'm sorry, Emmie," I said quietly, my voice thick with regret. "I'm sorry for everything."

She turned to face me, but her expression was hard, unreadable. "Just... leave it, Ryan. What happened between us last night... What we said... Nothing's changed because of this," she said. Her voice was cold.

Jen nodded, her face tense. "Listen to my sister. Leave us alone." The words sunk in deep.

I swallowed the lump in my throat and nodded. I understood. We might have discovered who was behind all of this and dealt with him, but the damage had been done. I had to respect that. But damn, the realization didn't make accepting it any easier.

When I got home later, I felt a strange sense of relief. The blackmailer had been exposed. Mitch would have the best lawyers working on the rest and everything would soon be finally moving toward some kind of resolution. I sank onto the couch, letting out a long breath. But I was still tense, consumed by , an anxiety that wouldn't go away. I switched on the TV but couldn't find anything to watch. I needed a better distraction.

On impulse, I grabbed my phone, brought up Sophie's number. She'd said I should keep in touch.

Hey, it's Ryan. How are you?

Her reply to my text came almost instantly.

I'm good. It's nice to hear from you. How's things? Are you back at work yet?

I didn't tell her that I'd been at the office this morning. That would be hard to explain.

No, I'm still suspended. Bored. I thought maybe we could meet up or something?

Again, she replied right away.

I'd like that.

I smiled and typed: *Drink this afternoon? At the coffee shop on the High Street? I've got some serious gossip to tell you.*

Sure, see you then. She replied. *Can't wait to hear what you have to say!*

I stared at my phone for a second, happy that someone was actually pleased to hear from me, talk to me, see me. I didn't know what the next chapter of my life would hold. I just knew I had to face it and it'd be easier if I had a friendly face to talk to about it.

Chapter Eight

I lay there, Sophie's warmth beside me in the quiet aftermath, her body pressed against mine as we both caught our breath. Her purple hair, partially shaved on one side, fell in messy strands around her face, giving her an edgy yet sexy look. I couldn't help but notice the silver spiked piercings that adorned her exposed ear, and the hint of rebellion in her gaze when she turned to look at me. Sophie was an unconventional beauty—I'd never been with anyone like her before and it was... intoxicating.

Sophie shifted slightly, and broke the silence. "I'm shocked about T.J.," she said, voice still soft with desire. She pulled herself up slightly, and propped herself up on one elbow, her soft brown eyes locking onto mine. "I never thought he was capable of something like that."

"Me neither," I replied, staring up at the ceiling, reliving that morning a week ago.

Sophie seemed to mull it over, her fingers tracing light patterns over my bare chest. "So what now? Are you going to get the money back?"

I shook my head, my mind clouded by everything that had happened,. I was still reeling from it. "T.J. still denies he has any blackmail money. He swears he hasn't taken anything. Emmie and Jen don't want to go to the police. I don't know why. Maybe they're scared of more coming out, but I can't say for sure." I knew why but I wasn't going to tell Sophie the sisters' dirty secret. "Right now, Mitch, Ethan, and Nate are doing everything they can to make sure Jen is okay. Her salon's safe. They've got a team of lawyers working on it. That's all I know."

Sophie seemed to consider this for a moment, her eyes drifting downward, her cupid's bow lips pulling into a small frown. She looked back at me, her eyes softening. "I'm sure Mitch will sort it out. He's a resourceful guy."

"Yeah," I replied. "I hope so."

I was content with Sophie beside me, but my thoughts drifted, as they had done for the past week. Where was Emmie now? What was she doing? Was she with Craig again? Mitch had texted, warned me that she was hanging out with the gym trainer again. It didn't feel right how everything had changed between us. Part of me wanted to reach out to her, tell her we'd made a mistake, that we still had something to fight for. But I knew she was right. Too much water had passed under the bridge. Too much damage had been done.

Sophie leaned closer, her lips brushing my ear. "What's going on in that head of yours?" she whispered, her voice teasing, yet soft with concern.

I turned to her, and tried to focus. "I'm just thinking about everything," I confessed. "T.J.'s actions affected so many people. Hurt so many people. It's hard to accept how much everything's changed. He's lost his job but you've left too. Helen doesn't know when I can go back. The salon is no longer completely Jen's. Emmie and I..."

Sophie didn't respond immediately. She was giving me space to work through it. Her body pressed closer to mine, her nakedness and warm breath on my neck stirring me again. But despite her proximity, I felt distant. My thoughts remained elsewhere—regrets, doubts, wishing things had turned out differently.

Her hand slid beneath the sheets, fingers gently caressing the skin of my thigh as she leaned in closer, her breath warm against my ear. "You know," she murmured, "I've always said you could do so much better than her." Her voice had a playful edge, but I sensed something else—something more sincere that I hadn't expected. "Don't let Emmie mess with your head anymore. Things will get better now. I promise."

I didn't respond immediately, just let her words hang between us. Sophie wasn't wrong. A part of me felt like Emmie had torn everything apart with the lies and secrets. I shouldn't let her continue to ruin my life. I had to move forward and take the opportunities that life presented me with now.

Sophie didn't wait for me to reply. She pressed closer, her thigh sliding over mine, and I felt the softness of her shaved pussy at my hip as she let

out a contented sigh. "I'm just glad we're here now, together. This is nice," she said, her voice almost too sweet, as if trying to convince both of us. "We've got something real. You and me. We don't need all that other drama. I won't ever treat you like she did."

I swallowed hard, and tried to ignore the conflict that stirred deep within me. Sophie was right in some ways. She'd been happy to see me when we met up. She was present, comforting, supportive. That first day, we'd just talked. I'd poured out my heart and she'd listened and nothing else had happened. The next day, she invited me to her place and we'd talked more, until she kissed me and told me to come to bed. And I listened. I'd been with her since then and I was glad. Maybe we could make something together. Sophie certainly didn't have the baggage that Emmie carried.

She tilted her head, and studied my face with an uncomfortable intensity. "What is it?" Her voice was softer now, more curious than demanding. "Do you still feel guilty for being here? With me? Don't. She's with Craig now, remember."

"No," I lied. "I'm not thinking about her. Fuck her."

Sophie smiled and her lips were on mine before I could think. She kissed me deeply, with a sense of urgency that pulled me back into the moment. Her body slid over mine, soft and warm, while her hands worked their way over my chest. the connection between us felt both familiar and strange at the same time.

"Let me make you forget all about her," Sophie whispered, her voice seductive. She pulled away just enough to look into my eyes. "You don't need her. You have me now."

I wasn't sure if I was trying to escape the reality of everything or if I really wanted to be there, but in that moment, I didn't care. I needed something to fill the emptiness. And Sophie was there. She kissed me again, and this time, it felt like a release, as if she took everything I had been holding inside. Despite cumming already once this morning, my cock responded and she felt it, a grin creeping across her face as she pushed herself upright, the sheets falling from her.

Her body was crazy hot. Her dusky skin glowed in the soft light sliding in between the bedroom curtains, the silver bar piercings in her light brown nipples catching and glimmering. I reached up, cupping her breasts, slightly more than a handful, enjoying their firmness as she reached down, and guided my hard cock into her soft, smooth wetness.

Sophie knew how to fuck, raising her slim hips just enough that I didn't slip out before sliding back down, her pussy gripped my cock perfectly, squeezing so tightly that I swore I saw stars. Her fingers found her clit, playing with the ruby stud that pierced her hood, pleasuring herself while we fucked.

I enjoyed her tits for a while longer, then let my hands slide down her sides. Her skin was so sensitive and ticklish that she giggled at the touch. I grabbed her hips, pulling Sophie down onto me while thrusting upwards, forcing myself deeper. She moaned, tossing her head back, and looked down at me, her purple hair falling into her eyes. She bit her lip sexily, shifted position, and turned so she was facing away from me. Now I had the perfect view of her tight ass as she began to grind onto me, rotating her body in tight circles. The move made my toes curl in pleasure until I came, my cock pulsing inside her, filling her with my cum.

When it was over, I lay there trying to catch my breath. My body still buzzed with a strange mixture of guilt and satisfaction. Sophie curled up next to me, her head resting on my chest as she traced lazy circles on my skin with a long-nailed finger.

"You're mine now," she murmured sleepily.

I didn't say anything, but let her words sink in. It was easier this way. But I couldn't help wonder how many times we'd have to do this. How long would it take for me to erase the thoughts of Emmie? It hadn't happened yet. Not yet. Maybe it never would.

"So you better work out what's happening after tomorrow," she continued. "We've spent some much time together these past few days, I'll miss you like crazy."

Sophie was moving to start fresh in Birmingham, and she wanted me to come with her. It wasn't the life I'd imagined for myself, not really. But there was something tempting in the idea of a new start away from all the tangled mess of my past. Away from the lies and the heartbreak. The longing for Emmie, still lingered in the corners of my mind, but Sophie's offer was... simple. Clean. No drama. Just her and me.

"I'll come visit you in a few days," I replied. "I just need to figure out what's happening with my job, and, well, some other stuff. But I'll visit. I promise."

Sophie smiled, leaned in closer, pressing her lips softly to mine. "I'm glad," she whispered, her hand tracing along my jawline. "I don't mind us

having a distance relationship for a while, Ryan. Just... as long as you come see me every week. Maybe stay the weekend sometimes, until you're ready to come live with me."

"I'll do that," I promised, the words spilling out without a thought. It wasn't a lie, but it wasn't the full truth either. I wasn't sure what was going to happen with us, but for the moment, this seemed easy.

Sophie smiled wider, a glint in her eyes. "I'll be worth it, I promise. No relationship-wrecking drama if you're with me. Just a fresh start." She kissed me again, the sweet moment settling around us like a blanket.

For a moment, I felt like everything would be to be okay. Maybe Sophie and I could make this work. Maybe I could leave the past behind. Maybe...

Later that evening, as I sat on the couch, still lost in my thoughts about what the next few days might bring, my phone buzzed. Luke's name flashed on the screen. I hadn't heard from him in days, not properly, not since the brief chat we'd had the day after our argument.

"Ryan," Luke's voice was mixed with relief and guilt. "I'm sorry I haven't been around. I've had a lot on my mind, the things about Natasha, you know... But I need to talk. I've been sorting things out and I really feel terrible about everything. Where are you, though? Your phone's been off. I called by the house but your neighbour, the hot red-head, said she hadn't seen you in days."

I sat up straighter, feeling a pang of guilt. "Yeah, I've just... been dealing with stuff, you know? But, sure, we can talk. It'll be good to catch up."

"She told me to say hi, if I got hold of you, and to remind you about her barbecue. She put it off last weekend due to the weather. It's this weekend now."

Luke took a long pause before speaking again, his voice quieter this time. "So... can we meet up? I just... I need to see you, Ryan. Things are messy, and I just want to make sure we're good, okay?"

I glanced over at Sophie, who was in the kitchen, washing up the dishes. "Yeah, Luke. We can meet. I'm free tonight, if you are."

As soon as I walked into the Red Lion, the familiarity of the pub gave me hope that life might finally get back to normal. Drinks with Luke, just like old times. Just the thought of it made me smile and when I spotted him sitting in our favourite corner booth, my smile grew wider. But Luke stared

into his pint, deep in thought. I slid into the seat next to him, giving a small nod of acknowledgment. He looked up at me with a faint, weary smile that didn't reach his eyes.

"Good to see you," I said, trying to sound casual. "You look like you've had a rough day. Everything okay?"

Luke just nodded, his eyes shifting to the bar. I followed his gaze, spotting his lovely fiancée. Natasha looked immaculate, as always, her long brown hair perfectly straightened, her black trouser suit fitting her shapely figure well. She caught sight of me, gave a quick wave, and headed over with a tray of drinks. She set it down, smiling brightly, but I could tell something was wrong here.

As Natasha sat beside him, Luke took a long sip of his pint, then looked at me, his jaw tightening.

"Ryan," he began, his voice steady but with an unusual edge. "We need to talk. I've had several long conversations with Natasha about everything that's been going on—about Emmie, the videos, and everything else. I think it's time we clear the air."

I blinked, a little taken aback. "Yeah," I said, taking a deep breath, then turned to the brunette. "I owe you both an apology. I shouldn't have suspected you, Natasha. I've been too wrapped up in this mess to even think straight. But the good news is we've found out who's behind everything. It's getting sorted."

Luke exchanged a quick glance with Natasha. She didn't seem surprised, but there was something in her expression that made me nervous.

"T.J.," I continued, "The tech guy that I worked with, he's the one behind it all. He copied the videos from Ethan's PC when he repaired it." I watched Natasha carefully, expecting a reaction but she didn't flinch. Her expression remained neutral.

"Ryan," she said, her voice calm but regretful, "I need to tell you the full truth." She glanced at Luke, then back at me. "I'll try to make this as short and brief as I can but we need to turn the clock back. Let me start by saying that I was furious when Ethan ended it with me for Emmie. Please keep that in mind. I didn't understand what was so special about her. So, I stalked her. I was obsessed with trying to figure out what made her different."

I was suddenly nervous. What the hell was going on?

"I had to know what Emmie had that I didn't," Natasha continued, her tone apologetic. "I wanted to get back at her. And you were a way I could

do that, so I decided to get close to you. If I could sleep with you, it would be... you know. Anyway, I was in your favourite coffee shop, waiting for a moment to talk to you, when I overheard you and Luke making plans to meet at the pub."

A memory was triggered. She was in the coffee shop... Maybe that was why I recognised her, and not just from porn videos. I waited for her to continue, but Luke took over.

"That was the day you cancelled on me," he explained. "The day I met Natasha. Do you remember?"

"Luke was there alone. I thought he might be my way in, so I approached him," Natasha continued. "Luke and I got talking and asked me out. I said yes, to get close to you."

She paused, gazing at Luke. Did he know all of this? What must he think? I didn't know what to say. My pulse was pounding. Natasha had been angry. Jealous. Driven by that familiar feeling of wanting revenge. But what she was saying now was worse. So much worse.

Natasha looked relieved when our eyes met, like she'd just unburdened herself.

"What does this mean? Are you splitting up?" I asked, feeling guilty all over again.

She shook her head vehemently. "No! I'm ashamed of my actions back then, but they led me here to Luke. We're happy, Ryan. We're in love, and we're getting married. I hate how it started, but as I got to know Luke, I fell for him. Truly, I did. And now, I'm happier than I've ever been."

"So why are you telling me all this?" I was confused.

Natasha's gaze drifted away. "Before I got together with Luke," she said, her voice so quiet that I could barely hear her over the music playing in the bar, "I was with Ethan, having dinner at the Dolphin Restaurant. His business partner was there with his girlfriend I instantly liked her. But then I ran into her again a few weeks later when I started stalking Emmie. And that's when things took a strange turn."

A cold shiver ran down my spine. I knew this was leading somewhere I wouldn't like.

"She accused Emmie of splitting her and her partner up," Natasha continued, turning emotional. "She was angry, just like me. But then we started talking, and we realized we both wanted the same thing—revenge on Emmie."

Helen's words popped into my head unbidden. Emmie split her and her partner up.

I know I've been a bit of a bitch in the office recently. That's because I've been going through a divorce. My husband cheated on me. It was ugly. It was painful. But you know what I didn't do? Let it interfere with my work.

Helen. She could have been with Mitch. He was one of our clients and a business partner of Ethan. I knew she'd been out for dinner with him. Was she in on it? Acting with T.J.? Or did she set him up? It was convenient that she'd found the evidence on his PC. Was that why Natasha was telling me all of this? The blood drained from my face, but Natasha kept going.

"I had a plan. I made copies of the videos of Emmie from Ethan's computer. I could expose her. But I daren't follow through with it. However, my new friend was more daring."

I couldn't stop myself from pressing. "And you gave her the videos?"

"Yes." Natasha sounded reluctant to make the admission. "I gave them to her on a USB drive."

My breath caught in my throat. It had to be the red USB stick in Jen's car. I didn't know what to think. It was all too much, too fast. "And then what happened?"

"I changed my mind. I couldn't do it. When I realised I loved Luke, I didn't care about Ethan anymore or getting back at Emmie. So I called her and told her to destroy the videos. She said she understood and agreed to let it go. I thought that was the end of it... until last week when Luke told me what was going on, And that you suspected me of being the blackmailer."

My mind was spinning. I didn't know what to say. "I know the blackmailer wasn't you. It was T.J. Are you saying he had an accomplice we don't know about? He didn't get the videos from Ethan's PC himself?"

"We heard that the person behind it had been caught," Luke said. "And we thought it was all over, until we found out T.J was the accused. It didn't fit with what Natasha told me."

Helen. You fucking bitch. Why would you do this to me?

"Was the business partner you're talking about named Mitch?" My voice was steady, but my heart was hammering in my chest.

"Yeah," Natasha replied, her voice low and hesitant now. "Mitch was there. The woman... his companion, she had dyed hair, bright blue. And piercings, that alternative look, but she was pretty."

The world around me seemed to tilt. I wasn't even sure I could breathe. Sophie. The woman Natasha was talking about was Sophie. Not Helen. It had to be. I felt like I might throw up.

Luke looked at me, his brow furrowed with concern. "What is it, Ryan? What's going on?"

I stood abruptly, fighting the sudden truth pressing down on me. "I have to go. Everything makes sense now. Thanks for telling me all of this, but I really need to go."

Luke opened his mouth to protest, but I held up a hand, shaking my head. "It's fine. I'll explain later. I've got something I need to deal with. I didn't notice the time. I'll call you later."

They looked stunned by my abruptness, but they didn't stop me as I left. I rushed to Sophie's, my mind racing faster than the car as I drove recklessly down the streets. Should I call Mitch? Emmie? Part of me wanted to just call them right away, but I couldn't. I wouldn't let myself look even more of a fool than I already did. Had I really been sleeping with the enemy? Sophie needed to tell me I was wrong. I needed to confront her, make her tell me this wasn't true.

When I got there, I found Sophie on the couch watching TV. The sight of her so relaxed, the way she smiled when she saw me, made everything feel so normal. But it wasn't. Not anymore. If I was right, it never would be again.

"Hey," she said as I walked towards her, "You're back quick. Is everything okay?"

I froze in the doorway, her voice suddenly triggering another memory. A stark realisation struck me like a kick in the balls. The words in the blackmailer's last email.

You just watched the videos. I hope you enjoyed them. Now you know what disgusting, relationship-wrecking cunts Emmie and her sister are. You could do so much better than her, Ryan.

Then, earlier today, as we cuddled in bed.

"I'll be worth it, I promise. No relationship-wrecking drama if you're with me. Just a fresh start."

"You know, I've always said you could do so much better than her."

Sophie wasn't who I thought she was. Was she the fucking blackmailer?

I stood there for a moment, pretending that everything was normal, but my nerves tingled with anxiety. Sophie was completely oblivious to my

turmoil, still glued to the TV screen. Even so, I had to stay calm. Stay in control. I couldn't let her see through me before I proved this.

I casually made my way to the kitchen for a glass of water. The sound of the TV in the background was strangely soothing, almost masking the noise in my head.

Where would she hide something?

I'd pieced together the clues, but now I needed the proof. Her laptop. I hadn't seen one since I'd been here, but she had to have one.

Sophie didn't even glance up as I passed her, so I took my time. The house was small, cozy—with just enough nooks and crannies for someone to stash something they didn't want anyone to find.

I scanned the room quickly, looking for where she might hide something. The hallway? The cupboard under the stairs? Too obvious. Behind the couch? Nah, Sophie wouldn't be that careless. I had a feeling and followed my gut instinct.

Upstairs.

I moved quietly, careful to avoid the creaky floorboards. The bedroom door was slightly ajar, and I slipped inside without a sound. I walked to her drawers, opening them one by one. Clothes. Underwear. A few receipts. Jewellery. A vibrator. But no laptop.

Next, I crouched, lifting the dust ruffle under the bed. My breath caught in my throat when I saw it—a small, dark bag was barely visible tucked in the furthest corner. My pulse quickened when I pulled it out, the weight of it heavy in my hands.

I unzipped the bag slowly, but it was deafening in the quiet room. The contents turned the blood in my veins turned to ice.

Inside was a small laptop with a USB drive taped to the lid. The bag was also filled with cash. Stacks of crisp notes, neatly folded and bound with rubber bands, exactly like Jen had described. Jen's blackmail money.

My hand trembled as I pulled the phone from my pocket. I stared at Jen's name on the screen, my finger hovering over it. My mind was racing, but my hands were steady as I dialled her. It rang twice before she picked up.

"Hello?" she said, sounding surprised to hear from me.

"Jen, it's Ryan," I whispered, trying to keep my voice even. "I don't have time to explain. I just need you to answer a question. What was the money when it was taken from the car?"

"A dark green canvas bag. Like a little tote. With a zipper."

I looked at the bag I held. The same green canvas. Everything clicked into place. Sophie had the money. I knew what I'd find on that USB drive. The evidence was all right in front of me.

Before I could say anything else, Sophie spoke from behind me.

"Fuck. You worked it out, huh?"

I froze, my heart pounding in my chest. I hung up and slid the phone back into my pocket and slowly turned to see her standing in the doorway, arms crossed. A look of annoyance—and maybe fear—was on her face.

She knew. She knew that I knew.

"Sophie..." My voice was flat, a statement more than a question. She couldn't deny it now.

She stepped into the room, her face shifting to one of resignation as she became a silhouette against the light bleeding in from the landing. "I didn't want you to find out like this," she said softly. Too softly. "It doesn't have to change anything if you don't want it to."

"Why?" I asked, my voice hoarse. "Why, Sophie? Why did you do this?"

Sophie didn't answer right away. She stood there, a shadow against the light. "Do you think I did it for the money?" she asked, bitterly. "No. I did it because you needed to see the truth, Ryan. I wanted to make sure you were with me, not her. But you'd never see her for what she was if I didn't show you. You were blinded by her big tits and blonde hair. And then her whore of a sister gave me a way of turning my plan into something else. A gateway out of here. With or without you."

"What the fuck?" I shook my head, standing up with the bag. "Sophie. You're not making any sense."

"Mitch and I were going places. We had a future until he suddenly became obsessed with saving Emmie. His damsel in fucking distress. When I told him I didn't like him interfering in other people's relationships, trying to save another woman..." Her voice was rising as she spoke. She was almost manic. "I needed saving, Ryan. Why couldn't he save me?"

"Sophie," I took a step towards her. "Calm down."

"Don't tell me to calm down," she hissed, her venom stopping me in my tracks. "Mitch told me he loved her. He fucking loved her and not me. What's she got that I haven't? She's nothing but a fucking slut. Not only was she in the way of you and me, she got in the way of me and Mitch. I fucking hate her!"

Her vitriol stung like acid, scolding me. For a moment, I was lost for anything to say. Everything had been a game to her. Sophie had been playing us, all of us, from the start. But now, I knew the truth.

"Sophie," I repeated, keeping my voice low and steady despite the storm swirling inside me. "This is over. Get out of my way."

I took a step forward, moving past her and swiftly down the stairs but as I reached for the door handle, I heard her footsteps behind me. She was right there, frantic, desperate.

"Fuck you!" she screamed, voice laced with venom. "You think you've won? You think you're the good guy here, huh?"

Before I could open the door, Sophie lunged at me, slamming us into the wall. She grabbed for the bag, trying to rip it from my grip. I pushed her off, but she came back at me with fury in her eyes, wild, like an animal cornered.

I didn't want to hurt her, but I had to leave. I had to end this.

I yanked the door open, but as I stepped outside into the cool night air, Sophie scrambled after me, her nails scraping my arm as she tried to drag me back inside. Her breath was ragged, her body trembling with rage.

"Get the fuck off me!" I yelled, my voice raw. I tried to back away, but her hands clawed at my face. I felt a sharp sting and cried out.

Then Luke burst out of nowhere like a force of nature, grabbing Sophie by the arms and yanking her away from me. His grip was firm, but it was all muscle and strength, not the kind of fury that was boiling inside her.

"What the hell is going on here?" Luke's voice was sharp, but confused.

But before he could fully restrain her, Sophie's eyes locked onto Natasha, who had followed Luke. Without warning, Sophie wriggled free of Luke, then turned on Natasha, fist swinging. The punch landed square on Natasha's cheek, and I heard a sickening crack.

"Bitch!" Sophie shrieked, pure hatred in the sound. "This is you! You fucking told them!"

But Natasha didn't flinch. She was quick and stronger than I'd anticipated. She stepped forward and threw a punch back, right into Sophie's gut. Sophie staggered, but Natasha wasn't done. With a fluid motion, she slammed her fist straight into Sophie's face, knocking her to the ground.

Sophie sat stunned on the sidewalk, nose freely bleeding. Her eyes flickered between the three of us, her fury slowly fading to defeat. She

wiped her bloody nose, glared at Natasha, and stood, unsteady but angry.

“Don’t think you’ve won,” Sophie shouted, wiping the blood that flowed over her lips. Tears mixed with the rage on her face. She started laughing. “I don’t give a shit anymore. I did what I wanted to do. Emmie’s life’s ruined, and it’s all because of me!”

I felt blood dripping down my cheek. She’d scratched me during our struggle, but I stood tall, trying to stay calm. “Fuck off, Sophie,” I said with finality. “Go to Birmingham and never come back. If you do, I swear I’ll do something I’ll regret.”

Sophie’s face twisted in fury, her lip curling in a snarl. “You’re not worth it!” she spat. “You think you’re so fucking righteous now, huh? Go to hell, Ryan. I don’t care anymore.” She wiped at her tears, smearing her face with blood, shaking with rage.

With a final look of pure hatred, Sophie turned and stormed into her house, her body shaking with intense rage, slamming the door behind her. She was finished, I could tell. But the damage was already done. I was sick to my stomach over how it had all unfolded.

Luke turned to me, stunned, but concern etched into his face.. “You okay, mate? It’s a good job we followed you. She looked like she wanted to kill you.”

I glanced down at myself and saw the inflamed claw marks on my arm. The scratches on my cheek stung as I wiped the blood away. Natasha stepped closer and gently touched my injured arm.

“You’re alright, Ryan,” Natasha said softly. She looked relieved it was finished. “We’ve got you. It’s over.”

I stared at Sophie’s house one last time, knowing that part of my life was behind me now, but that didn’t make me feel better about the trail of wreckage she’d left in her wake.

I clutched the canvas bag tightly in my hand and nodded, still dazed. “I hope so.”

Chapter Nine

The sun was warm on my face despite the autumn chill in the air in Laura and Mark's back garden. The barbecue had been postponed a couple of times already because of the weather, but today was the perfect day. The sky was blue and clear of clouds and the scent of grilling food filled the garden, mingling with the earthy smell of fallen leaves that lay scattered around the yard.

The garden was packed with people. Music played softly from the speakers, and the sound of laughter and clinking glasses floated over the noise of the sizzling barbecue. Mark was at the grill, flipping burgers and sausages, while the others milled around the tables, plates in hand, chatting and laughing. Things almost felt normal again. Almost.

But my life was far from normal.

A week had passed since Sophie left, and I was still reeling from everything that had happened. I'd spent the last few days picking up the pieces, trying to make sense of it all. Sophie had disappeared without a trace, and I was trying my best to move on, but it wasn't easy. I had a feeling that nothing was going to be easy for a while.

Jen and Emmie had both reconciled with me. We'd talked things through—well, they'd talked and I'd listened, mostly. The details of what happened with the blackmail were finally out in the open, and while things were strained between Emmie and me, we were back on speaking terms. She was still with Craig, though, and I had to accept that. It didn't sit well with me, but I couldn't force her to change her mind.

Jen and I were in a better place now, too. We'd discussed things, and despite everything that had happened, she was still my sister-in-law, still family, still a friend. For now, anyway. Unless Emmie decided she wanted a divorce.

I wasn't really sure where things stood with Emmie, but for now, I was letting it go. I wasn't going to chase her anymore. I'd tried that before, and I had to face the fact that she was done with our relationship, as things stood, at least. Maybe it was better this way.

The barbecue was a distraction, a welcome one. I needed a break from the upheaval that Sophie's blackmail had caused. The laughter of friends filled the air, and if I forgot the events of the past few weeks, it could have almost been a normal get-together. People were enjoying themselves, talking about everything and nothing. Laura was circulating, laughing and joking, while Mitch hung back with me for a while, a beer in hand, chatting about the latest in his life.

"Not bad, huh?" Mitch said, nodding toward the grill. "Mark's cooking is top-notch."

"Yeah," I agreed, though my eyes drifted to Emmie talking to Jen and enjoying a glass of wine. Craig wasn't here with her today but still, I couldn't shake the image of them together. It was a weird mix of jealousy and resignation. I didn't know what to do with those feelings anymore.

"Hey, you okay?" Mitch asked, sensing my distraction. "You've been kinda quiet."

I shrugged, trying to play it off. "Yeah, just... thinking."

"About Emmie?" He shot me a look that told me he understood more than he was letting on.

I nodded, unwilling to hide it. "Yeah. I'm trying to wrap my head around everything. Seeing everyone here today... You know how it is."

Mitch didn't say anything for a while, just took a long sip of his beer. He'd been good to me since that night with Sophie, checking that I was okay—letting me say what I needed to say, or not saying anything at all. Sometimes, that was exactly what I needed.

A familiar voice interrupted the silence, and I turned to see Jen walking over to us, Pete by her side. They were still going strong, and it was good to see Jen smiling again, looking happier than I'd seen her in a long time.

"We're not interrupting you boys, are we?" Jen asked with a smile, her arm around Pete's waist.

“Nah,” Mitch said, waving it off. “Just talking about the usual stuff.”

“Good stuff?” Jen raised an eyebrow. “Or bad stuff?”

“Mostly good,” I said, offering her a small smile. “It’s nice to see everyone getting their lives back on track, you know?”

Jen nodded in understanding, her eyes lingering on me for a moment before she turned to Pete. “So, I was just talking to Ollie and Nate. They suggested we go to the Red Lion once the barbecue’s done. Max says the first round is on him.”

I turned my attention toward Max who was talking to a pretty dark-skinned woman, a friend of Laura and Mark’s. Then I saw Ollie and Nate, who were standing by the fence, talking quietly. I’d assumed they were just good friends, like many of the other couples here. I’d not really thought much about them as anything more than that. But as Jen said their names together, something clicked. The way they looked at each other. The way Nate was so comfortable with Ollie. It hit me then, the realization that they weren’t just friends.

“They’re together, aren’t they?” I asked, the surprise in my voice betraying me.

Jen looked at me like I was an idiot for not catching on sooner. “Yeah, they’ve been together for a while now. Emmie introduced them. She didn’t tell you?”

I shook my head, laughing a little at myself. “Guess I missed that one.”

Jen chuckled, but there was a softness in her smile as she looked over at the couple. “I think they’ve just been keeping it quiet. They didn’t want to make things weird.”

“Doesn’t seem to be bothering them now,” Mitch remarked, grinning as he looked at Ollie and Nate, who were clearly in their own world.

“Doesn’t bother me either,” I said, taking another drink. Everyone had their own stories, their own paths to follow. “And to think I suspected Nate of being one of Emmie’s lovers.”

Mitch chuckled and Jen and Pete left us, mingling with the other guests before talking to Kenji, Laura’s Japanese lover. Luke and Natasha were here too, gazing into each other’s eyes as they ate, the love between them obvious for all to see.

The afternoon slipped into evening, the sun dipping lower in the sky, casting a warm, reddish glow over the garden. Laughter rang out again, and I found myself losing track of time, just enjoying the moment. For a few

hours, I didn't have to think about what came next, or where Emmie and I stood with our marriage, or what Sophie had done. I was just here, with friends, with people I cared about, and maybe that was enough for now.

As the sun began to set, I found myself pulling away from the conversation, reflecting on how much had changed in the past few weeks. Things were moving forward. I was back at work on Monday, thanks to Mitch and Helen smoothing things over with the company. Jen had her money back, and she'd been genuinely delighted and thankful, tears in her eyes when I handed it over. It had felt good to do the right thing, despite what it had cost me.

Emmie stayed distant, and while I wanted to reach out, there was no point in forcing anything that wasn't meant to happen. She still had a lot to work through herself, and I had to respect that. The evening was drawing to a close, and the others were starting to filter out, heading to the Red Lion at Max's insistence.

I hid from them, heading back inside my house, not in the mood for wallowing further in the Red Lion. It had been nice to forget about everything for a while, but as I opened the door and stepped in, reality hit again. The house was quiet, too quiet, without Emmie.

I walked into the kitchen, putting on the kettle to make a coffee. There were beers in the fridge but I'd learned that drinking only made my melancholy worse. Then I heard footsteps behind me and turned to see Emmie standing in the doorway, just inside the house, her hazel eyes cautious but warmer than I'd expected.

I cleared my throat, trying to seem casual. "Hey, Emmie. If you're here to ask me to go to the Red Lion, I'm not going. I'm tired. Got a bit of a headache."

"I'm not going either." She smiled faintly, but there was an edge of uncertainty to it. "So... how are you? We haven't really talked much today, have we?" She stepped in further, closing the door behind her, but she didn't come any closer.

I nodded, glancing around for a moment, hoping she didn't notice Sophie's laptop and USB stick on the kitchen work surface. There were videos on there. Not just the four that I'd seen either. There were six more, another of Emmie and Ethan, one of Jen masturbating while the old man filmed, then two more of Natasha and finally two with women that I'd never seen before, other lovers of Ethan that he'd manipulated. Oddly, they

were all labelled 'Emmie' followed by a number, which suggested that Sophie had only ever watched the first couple and then assumed they were all Emmie—but now Emmie was here, and I was suddenly very aware of what I had been hiding. I tried to quickly reach for the laptop, but she noticed.

"New laptop?" she asked, curiosity in her tone.

"It's not new," I muttered, trying to close the laptop as smoothly as I could. "Just a work one, with... work stuff. Nothing important."

But Emmie had already noticed the USB stick. Her eyes flickered to it, and she gave me a questioning look. My heart started to pound in my chest.

"A new USB drive too," she noted, her voice softer now, but there was something else in her eyes, a flicker of suspicion.

I felt a wave of heat flush over my face. I shouldn't lie to her. Not any more but Emmie didn't push it further.

"I know I've been avoiding you, but we do need to talk," she said, her voice sounding strangely vulnerable, yet firm. She stepped closer, leaning against the table. "I'm... I'm done with Craig."

"You what?" My heart skipped a beat at her words. This was unexpected.

"I've split up with him," Emmie said, looking at me seriously, but there was a faint trace of relief in her voice. "I have my reasons."

I was quiet for a moment, unsure of what to say. "Why?" I finally managed to ask. "What reasons?"

Emmie shrugged lightly, crossing her arms, her expression guarded. "He's a nice guy, but honestly... he was just too keen. Too eager. I didn't want that. I don't want that. I don't want to commit to anything too quickly. He was too... full-on."

I nodded slowly. That made sense. Sophie had me feeling the same, before she turned out to be a psycho. Then Emmie said something else that caught me off guard, as if reading my mind.

"So... you and Sophie," she started, looking at me almost playfully, "Did you... you know? Sleep together?"

I nodded, feeling a mix of guilt and honesty rush through me. "Yeah. I'm not exactly proud of it."

Emmie studied me carefully, her expression unreadable. Then, after a pause, she spoke again, this time more teasingly. "Was she good?"

"Not good enough to be worth the trouble she caused," I replied, trying to be playful back but I couldn't help but wince slightly at the mention of the

woman that had split us up. “I... uh, I also slept with Laura,” I admitted quietly. I wasn’t sure why I was being so open with her, but I felt like she deserved the truth.

Emmie didn’t flinch. Instead, there was a small smile playing at her lips. “I knew. Somehow, I just knew.” She sighed, looking away for a second before meeting my eyes again. “I’m guessing she *was* good. Hey... you’ve got your own little post-Emmie body count going now. You’re beating me by one.”

“Really?” I forced a smile, struggling to tell whether she was angry or as fine with it as she seemed.

“Yes. I’ve only slept with Craig,” Emmie said, her voice steady, but there was a touch of vulnerability in it. “And I’m being honest with you now. I’ve never cheated on you before that. Everything that did happen, happened while we were apart, during that... that year. But when we were together, before and after, I stayed faithful.”

I stayed quiet for a moment, absorbing what she’d said. Her eyes gazed into mine, full of sincerity. I believed her. I could tell she was being truthful with me now.

“Where are you staying?” I asked. “If you’re not with Craig? With Jen? Ollie?”

Emmie paused for a moment, looking at me with a strange, almost wistful expression. “I’ve been staying at Jen’s. It’s a little awkward with Pete always being there. You know, with what happened with him, Max, and me.”

The openness of her reply, the mention of that foursome surprised me. She really was being honest. I nodded slowly, able to imagine how that might be weird.

She shifted on her feet, looking around the kitchen like she wasn’t sure where to start next. After a beat of silence, she asked, “Weren’t you making a coffee? I’ll have one while you’re at it. Oh, I still need to know about that laptop and the USB stick. That’s not yours, is it? I know you too well, Ryan. I know when you’re lying. And I’m guessing the USB stick is Sophie’s too?”

“Yeah,” I admitted, my voice a little hoarse. She was right. She did know me too well. “She had them hidden with Jen’s money so I took them, to make sure she didn’t have anything she could use against us in the future.”

Emmie raised an eyebrow, something unreadable flickering across her face. She wasn't angry, but she was definitely processing everything. "And?" she asked, her voice low and calm. "Did you watch them?"

I felt a pang of guilt, but I couldn't lie. I knew it was time to come clean. I had nothing to lose now.

"Yeah. No more secrets between us, right?" I said quietly. "I watched them. It's... I don't know. I just needed to know. I had to know everything." I couldn't bring myself to look her directly in the eye as I spoke, feeling the shame creep in, but Emmie didn't seem to react negatively at all.

"I agree," she said, her voice calm. "No more secrets. We need to be honest with each other, even though we're not together like we were before."

I looked up at her, startled by the clarity in her words. "Yeah. I'm with you on that. I'll tell you everything, whatever you want to know. No more pretending, if you promise to do the same."

"I can do that." She tilted her head slightly, studying me, as if she was measuring my words. Then, after a pause, she asked, "What can I ask you? Hmm. Let me see... How about this? Did you... get turned on by the videos?"

I froze, my throat tight. I had been dreading this question, if she ever asked it, but there was no way around it. I'd promised to be honest. This was the moment where the last of the walls between us needed to come down.

"I did," I admitted, feeling my face flush. "I didn't want to, but I did. I don't know, Emmie. It's... strange. Watching you with other men. But it also... got me horny. It's like a taboo fascination, a porn movie I shouldn't be watching."

She nodded slowly, as though she'd expected that answer. "I thought so," she said softly. "You've been wanking off to them, haven't you?"

I felt the heat rise to my face, but I didn't shy away from the question. "Yeah," I mumbled, unable to look her in the eyes. "I did. I mean, it's kind of freaky, but I couldn't help it. Even though you were with... someone else, it's still you. And you're gorgeous, so..."

She grinned, then looked at me for a long moment before her gaze softened. "It's not freaky, Ryan. I get it." Then she hesitated before adding, "I think I get a little... turned on too, thinking about you with Sophie and Laura. Maybe I'm the freaky one?"

I chuckled a little, feeling a mix of surprise and relief. “Everything’s freaky now, Emmie,” I said, the words coming out with a tinge of disbelief. “But yeah, I guess at least there’s something positive to come out of it all, if we both get horny thinking about what happened.”

She let out a quiet laugh, her face softening. “Yeah, there’s that. We’ve both learned a lot about ourselves, haven’t we? About what we want... and what we didn’t even know we wanted. Maybe we got together too young, Ryan. Before we got to really know ourselves, what we like, what we don’t.”

I nodded, taking in her words. It was true. We’d been so young when we first started dating. There were so many things we didn’t talk about, didn’t know about each other. And now, years later, it seemed like the world had changed around us. Our feelings had shifted, our desires had evolved.

“We fell in love,” I replied. “We couldn’t help it. And... I’m glad we met when we did. We’ve had some amazing times, made memories that I’ll always treasure.”

Emmie’s gaze softened as she took a breath, her eyes flickering nervously toward the floor before she met my eyes again. “I still love you, Ryan,” she said, her voice low and hesitant, as though testing the weight of her words. “But I’ve realized that... everything that happened during our break—the sex I had with other people, then Craig—it made me realize there’s more of myself I need to explore.”

“I love you too,” I whispered, my throat tight, a knot forming in my stomach. “I miss you terribly. But I get it. I do. I found it... liberating, when I was with Laura... and Sophie, if I’m honest with myself. But I’d give anything for us to go back to how we were before. I really would.”

She didn’t say anything. She just watched me, her expression unreadable.

“But we both know that’s not possible now,” I added, feeling foolish. “You’re right. We both changed. We’re different people now.”

“Not just us,” Emmie whispered, suddenly visibly nervous. “Everything has changed. There’s something else, Ryan. Something I need to show you.”

Her expression shifted again, this time more serious, as if she had been holding something back. She reached into her bag, her fingers brushing against something inside, and my heart skipped as she pulled out a pregnancy test kit. She held it out to me, her face unreadable.

“I’m pregnant,” she said softly, her voice a little shaky. “It’s yours, I swear. The dates all add up. I know you’ll want a paternity test, and I’m okay with that. But I’m telling you now—the baby is yours. You’re going to be a father, Ryan.”

The world seemed to stop for a second. My breath caught in my throat as I stared at the test, the two lines indicating a positive result, then back at her. A baby. Ours. It felt like everything had shifted in an instant, the ground beneath me unsteady.

“Holy shit,” I said, the words coming out in a stunned rush. I could feel the panic rising in me, a thousand thoughts racing through my mind. But there was something else too—elation. Joy. Even though everything had become more complicated than I could ever imagine, the thought of being a father stirred something deep in me.

I stepped toward her, my head spinning, but at the same time, a new sense of clarity seemed to settle over me. “Come home, Emmie,” I said, my voice firm. “You don’t have to commit to anything, but... come live here. You said it’s awkward with Jen. You’re carrying our baby. We don’t have to be together like we were. But we can cohabit. I’ll look after you through this pregnancy. We can be good co-parents. We can make this... whatever relationship we have... we can make it work—for the baby.”

Her eyes softened, and I could see the doubt still in her gaze, but there was something else there too—something warmer. “A baby can’t fix a marriage, Ryan,” she said, her voice quiet. “And I don’t want to stay together just because of the baby. But... the baby does deserve a united, close mother and father. And we can be that. We don’t have to have any labels. No commitments beyond being good people, good parents to this little one.”

I nodded, feeling the truth of her words sink in. “No labels. Just honesty. Let’s see how this goes. No pressure. Just... come back home. We don’t have to have sex, or even sleep together. I’ll go in the guest room. You can still date other guys. And if you meet the right guy, then I guess... I’ll cross that bridge when we get to it.”

Emmie leaned back slightly, her lips curling into a teasing smile, her eyes sparkling with mischief. “No sex? Who says I don’t want sex? Are you saying I have to settle for imagining you with Laura while I masturbate? Perhaps I should just film myself with my next date,” she teased, her voice

dripping with that same playful energy I remembered so well. “Maybe that’ll get you worked up.”

I just stared at her for a moment, the shift in the conversation sparking something deep inside me. The bluntness of it—the way she was teasing me—was like a door opening to something new between us. I couldn’t deny the heat building in my chest, the sudden pull of desire. I didn’t know whether it was because of the honesty or just the thought of her with someone else, but I found myself growing hard yet again at the idea of her with another man, filming it for me to watch.

“Yeah,” I said, my voice a little hoarse, the tension in my words betraying me. “That would probably work. Watching you with someone else... that’d definitely get me going. And now I’m... well, very horny. Thanks for that.”

I laughed, trying to lighten the tension between us and she smiled then, stepping forward to kiss me gently, a tenderness in her touch that spoke of something new—something that could work between us, even if it wasn’t the same as it once was.

The kiss deepened, and for a moment, everything outside of us disappeared. We were together, not as a couple trying to force something that wasn’t there, but as two people enjoying a spontaneous moment.

Emmie’s hand was at my jeans zipper, undoing it, yanking down my pants, her hand finding my semi-hard cock and stroking it urgently. Her touch was electric, and I groaned against her lips, my body responding, my hard-on stiffening instantly. There was no hesitation, no second-guessing. It was as if everything we’d just talked about—the baby, our uncertain relationship—only fuelled the raw need between us.

Emmie pulled back just enough to meet my eyes, her hand still working me in a slow, deliberate rhythm. Her lips curled into that sly smile I knew too well. “Think we can keep things casual?” she teased, her voice breathy, her free hand slipping under my shirt to run her nails across my chest.

I couldn’t help but smirk, though my breathing was already ragged. “Casual works for me,” I said, my voice low as I tugged her closer, my hands finding the curves of her hips, pulling her into me.

Without another word, she guided me backward until the edge of a kitchen chair hit the backs of my knees. I fell onto it, and Emmie followed, her dress riding up her thighs. She straddled me, her hands framing my face as she kissed me again, this time deeper, hungrier. My hands slid up her legs, the smoothness of her skin making my head spin.

Her hips pressed against mine, grinding slowly, teasing me through the thin barrier of her tiny black thong. I could feel the heat of her, the wetness already seeping through, and it drove me wild. "Jesus, Emmie," I murmured, my hands gripping her hips tighter as I tried to slow things down.

She pulled back slightly, her eyes locking onto mine, a spark of playful defiance in her gaze. "You don't get to call all the shots anymore, Ryan," she said, her tone commanding but soft, her fingers slipping under my shirt and dragging it over my head. "If we're going to do this, we're doing it my way."

I nodded, speechless, as she shifted to peel off her dress, revealing her smooth, bare skin and a black lace bra that I'd never seen before, that left little to the imagination. My hands roamed her thighs, her back, desperate to touch every inch of her as she leaned in to kiss me again.

Her hand slid between us, pulling her thong to one side, guiding me into her shaved pussy, and when she sank down, taking me in, it was like a dam breaking. The tension, the desire, the unspoken emotions—it all came pouring out. She moved with a slow, deliberate rhythm, her head falling back, a soft moan escaping her lips as she began to ride my cock.

"God, I missed this," she whispered, her hands on my shoulders as she rode me.

I could barely form words, the sight of her above me, her body moving with such confidence and ease, stealing my breath. My hands moved to her breasts, my thumbs brushing over the hardened peaks of her nipples through the lace. Her gasp was music to my ears, and I leaned forward, capturing one in my mouth, biting gently through the fabric.

She whimpered, her hips bucking against me, and I felt her tighten around me, her body trembling. "This feels so good," she urged, her voice breaking, her fingers threading through my hair and tugging. "Just let me fuck you."

I did as she asked, letting her take control, letting her set the pace. It wasn't just sex; it was something more—a reclaiming of herself, of us. The room filled with the sounds of our bodies coming together, the shared gasps and moans of two people rediscovering each other.

As Emmie moved above me, her pace quickening, I felt myself teetering on the edge. My hands gripped her hips tightly, guiding her rhythm as my breathing grew ragged. The slick heat of her, the soft sounds escaping her

lips, and the intoxicating scent of her skin all combined into a crescendo I couldn't hold back much longer.

And then, I heard it—the faint creak of the kitchen door.

Emmie froze above me, her head whipping toward the sound, her chest heaving as we both registered what was happening. Standing in the doorway, looking equally stunned and apologetic, was Mitch. His eyes widened as he took in the scene, and he quickly averted his gaze, his hand shooting up in an awkward gesture of retreat.

"Shit, I'm sorry," he stammered, his voice low and urgent. "I didn't mean to interrupt. I went to the pub, but when you two weren't there, I thought I'd come back, check to make sure everything was okay. Laura said she saw you come inside, Emmie, so I figured... I knocked, but no one answered, and the door was open, so I—"

His stuttering trailed off as his eyes flicked back to us for a brief moment, lingering just a second too long before he turned his head away again. "Anyway, I'll leave you to it," he finished, stepping back.

But before he could disappear, Emmie glanced down at me, her expression unreadable for a split second. Then, as if some silent understanding passed between us, she climbed off me, her movements unhurried, her gaze locked on Mitch.

"Mitch," she called softly, her voice steady but warm.

He paused, halfway through the doorway, and turned back to look at her, his confusion evident, but also his attraction to her obvious in his gaze. "Yeah?"

She crossed the room toward him, her bare legs and barely-contained breasts commanding his attention. Her confidence was palpable, her intentions unmistakable, and I couldn't tear my eyes away as she reached him, standing just a breath away.

"Stay," she said simply, her fingers brushing his forearm. "We want you to stay."

He looked from her to me, his brow furrowed in disbelief, his lips parting as if to protest, but no words came out. Before he could object, Emmie leaned in, her lips capturing his in a slow, deliberate kiss. I saw the way his body stiffened, his hands hovering at his sides as if unsure whether to touch her, but it didn't take long for him to melt into it. His hands came up to cup her face, his hesitation giving way to need.

Watching them, a strange mixture of arousal and acceptance washed over me. This wasn't jealousy. It wasn't betrayal. It was something raw, something honest. Emmie broke the kiss, her hand slipping into Mitch's, and she turned to look at me, her eyes searching mine.

I nodded, my heart racing. "Let's go upstairs," I said, my voice low but steady.

Emmie smiled softly, leading Mitch by the hand as they moved toward the stairs. I followed, the anticipation thick in the air, the unspoken agreement between us binding in a way I never thought possible.

When we reached the bedroom, Emmie turned to Mitch, pulling him close for another kiss, her hands threading through his hair. I watched as his hands slid down her sides, his initial uncertainty giving way to boldness. She turned toward me then, her hand outstretched, beckoning me closer.

"What's happening?" Mitch said softly, his eyes switching between the two of us uncertainly.

"Sshh," she said softly, her eyes filled with a mix of mischief and trust. "Just trust me."

Mitch's breathing was uneven, his chest rising and falling as he stood with Emmie's hands on his chest. He glanced at me, a hesitant smile tugging at his lips. "So... I guess this means you two are back together?"

I shook my head, stepping closer, the tension between the three of us palpable. "Not exactly," I said, my tone calm but deliberate. "This isn't about going back to what we were. It's about something different—something honest. Emmie and I... we've changed. And part of that change is embracing what excites us, what fulfills us, even if it's not conventional. We're not tying ourselves down to the old rules anymore."

Mitch looked to Emmie, his brows furrowing. She smiled softly, reaching up to touch his face. "Ryan's right," she said gently. "This isn't about fixing the past. It's about embracing the now. And right now, I want you, Mitch. And I know you've always wanted me. It's not about choosing one person over another, Ryan over you, you over him, it's not like that any more. It's about exploring this, together."

Mitch hesitated, his gaze flickering between the two of us again. Then he let out a nervous chuckle, his hands coming up to frame Emmie's face. "You're right. I've always wanted you, Emmie," he murmured. "But this... I never imagined this."

“Neither did we,” I said, stepping behind Emmie and sliding my hands to her hips. “But it’s real. So... are you okay with it, or not?”

He exhaled slowly, his expression shifting from disbelief to something more resolute. “Okay,” he said finally. “I’m in.”

Emmie’s smile widened, and she kissed him again, her almost-naked body pressing against his as I stepped back to watch. The sight of them together was intoxicating, the way her fingers tangled in his hair, the way his hands roamed the bare skin of her back.

Mitch lifted her onto the bed as she reached for the buttons of his shirt, her deft fingers making quick work of them. Her body arched as he leaned down, his mouth trailing kisses along her neck and down to her chest, freeing her breasts from the lace of her bra, her nipples hard as his mouth found them, sucking them softly. Her soft moans filled the room, and I felt myself harden again at the sound.

I stood back, watching as Mitch undressed her fully, tossing her bra across the room, his eyes enjoying the sight of her bare tits. Then she arched her back again, lifting her hips so he could take down her thong, exposing herself to him fully. His mouth went back to her nipples, lips trailing over her skin, his hands sliding between her thighs to part them.

“I’ve wanted to see you like this for so long,” he sighed, drinking in the sight of Emmie, her large breasts heaving as she breathed heavily, her pussy glistening with wetness. Then she gasped as he kissed his way down her body, his mouth making its way to her pussy, and I couldn’t look away as he parted her folds with his fingers and then delved his tongue into her wetness. My own arousal was overwhelming, the sight of her writhing under his touch like a live wire sparking through me.

When Mitch finished stripping, his hard cock standing proudly in front of him, much bigger than mine, Emmie looked over at me, her eyes glazed with lust. “Come closer, Ryan,” she murmured, her voice thick with desire as he finally moved over her, his body aligning with hers.

I moved to the bed, sitting on the edge next to them and Emmie’s lips curled into a wicked smile as she wrapped her legs around Mitch’s waist, pulling him into her. The way her body tensed as his long, thick cock slid inside, stretching her pussy lips, filling her like I could never do, was like nothing I’d ever experienced.

“Fuck me,” Emmie moaned and Mitch did, lifting her thighs, pressing them back against her chest and driving his cock into her deeply. This

wasn't like watching her on a laptop screen. This was real, raw, visceral. As they fucked on the bed, Mitch slamming into her hard, causing her to climax within minutes, I took it all in, the sounds of his balls slapping against her, Emmie's grunts and groans at his physicality, the sight of her eyes rolling back, her tits wobbling back and forth with the motion, the smell of their sex as they fucked.

When Mitch turned to look at me, pulling out, his breath ragged as he sprayed rope after rope of sticky white cum all over my wife's tits, I knew it was my turn. I stepped forward, shedding my clothes as Emmie reached for me, her hands pulling me closer, on top of her, inside her. Mitch stayed by our side, watching as intently as I had, as I fucked her. But I was so turned on that I came almost instantly, my cock exploding inside her. She giggled when I apologised, her voice soft as she told me not to worry.

It was over and we lay together in a tangled heap, our breaths slowing, Mitch and Emmie's bodies slick with sweat, all three of us spent. Emmie nestled between us, her head resting on my chest, her hand on Mitch's. For a moment, everything felt perfectly balanced, as if this was exactly where we were meant to be.

But as the quiet settled, I felt a pull to get up, to clear my head. I slipped out of bed, wrapping a sheet around my waist as I walked to the window. The sun had set now, the sky was almost black, the backyard bathed in the soft glow of the moon. I looked up at it through the glass, wondering how this new dynamic between Emmie and I would work out, how it would shape us moving forward, as we prepared to become parents, in whatever form our relationship took.

And then I saw her—Laura—standing in the backyard, looking up at me, the tip of the cigarette in her hand glowing bright orange. She took a pull from it, puffing the silver smoke out into the cool air, a knowing smile playing on her lips. Then lifted a hand in a slow, deliberate wave. She's seen the three of us. This was going to get complicated. But it was also going to be a lot of fun.

Chapter Ten

Epilogue

As I followed Helen up the sleek staircase of her immaculate home, I couldn't help but admire the subtle sway of her hips beneath her tailored trousers. Everything about her radiated control—her perfectly polished appearance, her deliberate movements, even the powerful scent of her almost-masculine perfume that lingered as she ascended ahead of me. Yet, lately, I'd been privy to the softer side of her and tonight, she displayed a vulnerability that I'd not seen before.

"Your house is amazing," I said, my voice cutting through the silence. The walls were lined with modern art, each piece likely worth more than my car. Recessed lighting bathed the space in a warm glow, highlighting the flawless design of the twisting staircase.

Helen glanced back at me, her full, crimson-painted lips curling into a faint, almost self-deprecating smile. "All thanks to Ethan," she said, her tone dry. "He's still paying for it through the divorce. Might as well enjoy it, right?"

I chuckled, though the mention of her ex carried a sharper edge. Ethan—her former husband, apparently still her benefactor, but also the man who had diverted Emmie from her innocent path—his was a name that I didn't enjoy hearing, even though neither Emmie or I had anything to do with him any more.

We reached the huge, impressive master bedroom, and she paused at the threshold, turning to face me. The confident mask she wore so easily slipped for just a moment, revealing something raw beneath. "I'm nervous," she admitted, her voice softer than I'd ever heard it. "It's been a long time since I had sex with anyone. But... I'll admit I'm curious. Sophie, Emmie, the neighbour you mentioned—they all seemed to think you're worth the chase. I'm interested to see what all the fuss is about."

I stepped closer, close enough to smell her perfume again and detect the slight trembling of her body, and gave her a small, reassuring smile. "Let me show you."

I reached for her, my hands finding her waist as my lips met hers. My boss tasted of red wine, a drink downstairs earlier to calm her nerves. Helen hesitated for only a fraction of a second before leaning into the kiss, her lips parting to invite me deeper. I kissed her slowly at first, my tongue meeting hers, and I enjoyed the way her tense posture relaxed under my touch. My hands slid down her sides, tracing the curve of her hips, before drifting up to the buttons of her crisp, white blouse.

Her breath hitched as I undid each one with deliberate care, exposing her smooth, pale skin and the delicate black gossamer of her bra. The blouse slipped from her shoulders, falling to the floor, and I took a moment to drink her in. She was stunning, her figure both elegant and sensual, her body toned in ways that hinted at the discipline she clearly carried into every aspect of her life.

“Beautiful,” I murmured, and her cheeks flushed slightly, a rare crack in her normally composed bearing.

She reached for my shirt, her fingers shaking as she pushed it up and over my head before tossing it to one side. Her hands explored my chest, her perfectly manicured white nails scraping gently over my skin, gentle but possessive, as if she were claiming this moment for herself. I kissed her again, deeper this time, guiding her toward the bed.

When her shapely calves hit the mattress, she sat, her hands moving to undo the zipper of her trousers. I knelt before her, stopping her with a gentle touch. “Let me,” I said, unzipping and then sliding the fabric down her legs to reveal matching black, see-through panties. She looked down at me, her dark eyes filled with desire but also trepidation.

I kissed her thighs, surprised to see a large, beautiful tattoo, a black tiger design on the outside of one thigh. I trailed my lips upward, over the tattoo, and she shivered under my touch, her fingers pushing through my hair. “A teenage mistake,” she explained, referring to the motif on her leg.

“I like it,” I replied softly. “It’s sexy.”

“Good,” she sighed. “Now don’t talk, Ryan. Just... do what you want.” The sound of my name on her lips sent a jolt through me, and I pressed my mouth against the delicate fabric covering her between her legs, feeling the heat of her through it.

Her moan was soft and restrained, her hips lifting slightly as if to urge me closer. But I wanted to savour this. I wanted to make her feel wanted, adored, in a way Ethan hadn’t for years. I slid her panties down, exposing

her completely, enjoying the sight of her precisely trimmed, dark landing strip, and kissed her lightly on her swollen clit, making her shudder, before exploring her with my tongue. She gasped, her hands gripping my shoulders, her body arching against me as I found a rhythm, a tight circle over the pink bud that made her tremble again.

Her orgasm came quickly, her cries filling the room, no longer restrained, as she came apart beneath me. I rose, kissing my way back up her body, and she pulled me onto the bed with surprising strength. “Not yet,” she whispered as I undid my belt, her nails raking lightly down my back as she guided me over her. “I want to suck you first.”

She sat up, pushing me away, peeling away my shorts as I kicked off my jeans. She looked at my already-hard cock for a second, then up at me, a twinkle in those dark eyes and a nervous smile on her lips. Then she took me in her mouth, the exquisite feeling making me gasp in pleasure. It was surreal, watching my boss suck my cock, but so many things had taken place in the past few months that I no longer questioned the reasons why things happened. I just embraced them.

Once I was hard, she melted back on to the bed. “Put it in me,” she said in the softest, quietest voice I’d ever heard from her. I positioned myself between her legs, pausing just long enough to meet her gaze. Her eyes were dark with need, her lips parted as she nodded, her nails poised to rake my back. When I pushed inside her, we both let out a groan, the tightness of her not wholly unexpected, pulling on the skin of my rock-hard erection as it slowly slid inside.

I moved slowly at first, letting her adjust, enjoying the way her body responded to mine. Her hands gripped my arms, her legs wrapping around my waist as her moans grew louder, more desperate. “God, Ryan,” she gasped, her nails digging into my flesh as I quickened my pace, driving deeper, harder.

Every sound she made, every movement of her body beneath me, pushed me closer to the edge. I kissed her fiercely, swallowing her cries as she came again, her body tightening around me, pulling me into her orgasm.

Then I rolled onto my back, pulling her still-quivering body with me, pushing upwards into her, feeling the clench of her around me. Then she sat, breathless, her dark eyes gazing down at me wantonly.

“Take off the bra,” I instructed her and she complied, reaching behind her to undo the catch, letting it fall away so that her large, pendulous but nicely-

shaped breasts swung free, invitingly in front of me. I held them in my hands, caressing her small, hard nipples with my thumbs, enjoying the sensation as she started to ride me, riding up the length of my cock before crashing down, enveloping me in her pussy.

I came just moments later, the pleasure crashing over me in waves, my seed pulsing inside her as she kept my dick trapped inside her, milking every drop from it with the tightness of her, leaving us both breathless and trembling when I was spent.

For a long time, we lay tangled together, the room filled with the sounds of our slowing breaths. Eventually, Helen slipped out of bed naked, walking to the dressing table in the corner. She picked up a small device there—a discreet video camera—and pressed a button, turning off the faint red light I hadn't noticed earlier.

I sat up, propped on one elbow, watching her with curiosity. "You recorded that?"

She turned, a wicked smile curling her lips. "Ethan had fun cheating on me, fucking your wife," she said, her voice dripping with satisfaction. "Now you've gotten to fuck his wife, or ex-wife, I should say. And I'm going to annoy the hell out of him by showing him. Let him see what he lost."

I stared at her, equal parts amused and impressed by her boldness. She walked to the closet, her expression softening as she gazed at me while wrapping a beautiful white silk robe around her shapely figure.

"Drink?" she asked lightly, as if the last hour had been nothing more than an ordinary work meeting. "Before we go for round two?"

"Round two?"

Helen laughed softly, the sound low and rich, as she leaned in closer, her lips brushing my ear, her fingers trailing down the length of my softening cock. "Oh, Ryan," she purred, her voice full of promise. "If you want that payrise I promised, you had better get used to this. I'm just getting started."

Afterword

Thank you so much for reading the 'I Know Who You Did Last Summer' series and for joining Ryan, Emmie, and the rest of the cast on this rollercoaster of love, betrayal, and redemption. Your support and dedication as a reader have meant the world to me, and I hope you've found the twists, turns, and explosive moments as gripping as I've intended.

I want to give a special thanks to each one of you for being part of this journey and I hope you checked out the book—exclusive epilogue! It's only available in the book and gives a sneak peek into what happens next for these characters—offering a final glimpse of what the future holds for Ryan and Emmie, and hopefully leaving just enough to keep you thinking long after the last page is turned!

I'm so grateful you chose to read this story and hope it's been as thrilling for you as it has been for me to write. And also, a big thank you to Kenny Wright and Kirsten McCurran for helping me edit this LONG final part of the story.

Until next time, and as always, thank you for your support and stay horny!

Paul

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About The Author

Paul Garland is an author of erotic novels and short stories, guaranteed to keep you turning the lust-filled pages until the early hours of the night. He lives with his wife and two children in a small house in the suburbs of Sheffield, England along with a lazy green budgerigar, an African Grey parrot that curses and a tubby tabby cat which would love to eat either. (Preferably the vulgar-tongued parrot.)

He has been writing since the turn of the millennium but only turned to the erotica genre in 2018 with his *Cerulean Erotica Presents* series and *No Angels* series of books which rapidly gained him a following. In 2020, he began '*The Cuckold Collection*,' a brand new collection of cuckold-themed books and two new series of shorter stories: *The No Angels Stories*, *The Sexy Season Stories* and *The Cerulean Archives*. 2022 began two series, *Holiday Hotwives* and *A Size Queen Story* and 2023 introduced a new series, *Improper Investigations* and the return to the *Cerulean Archives* with *I Found A Box Of Photos Of My Wife... And Her Ex*. 2024 sees another new series along with continuations of his current running series, the *My Wife* series and the return of *The Detective Hotwife*.

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